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In the Sacklers' Backyard

The Future of Connecticut's Opioid Epidemic Response

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CONFRONTING CRIME IN FAIR HAVEN THROUGH COMMUNITY ORGANIZING

BY **CALEB DUNSON**

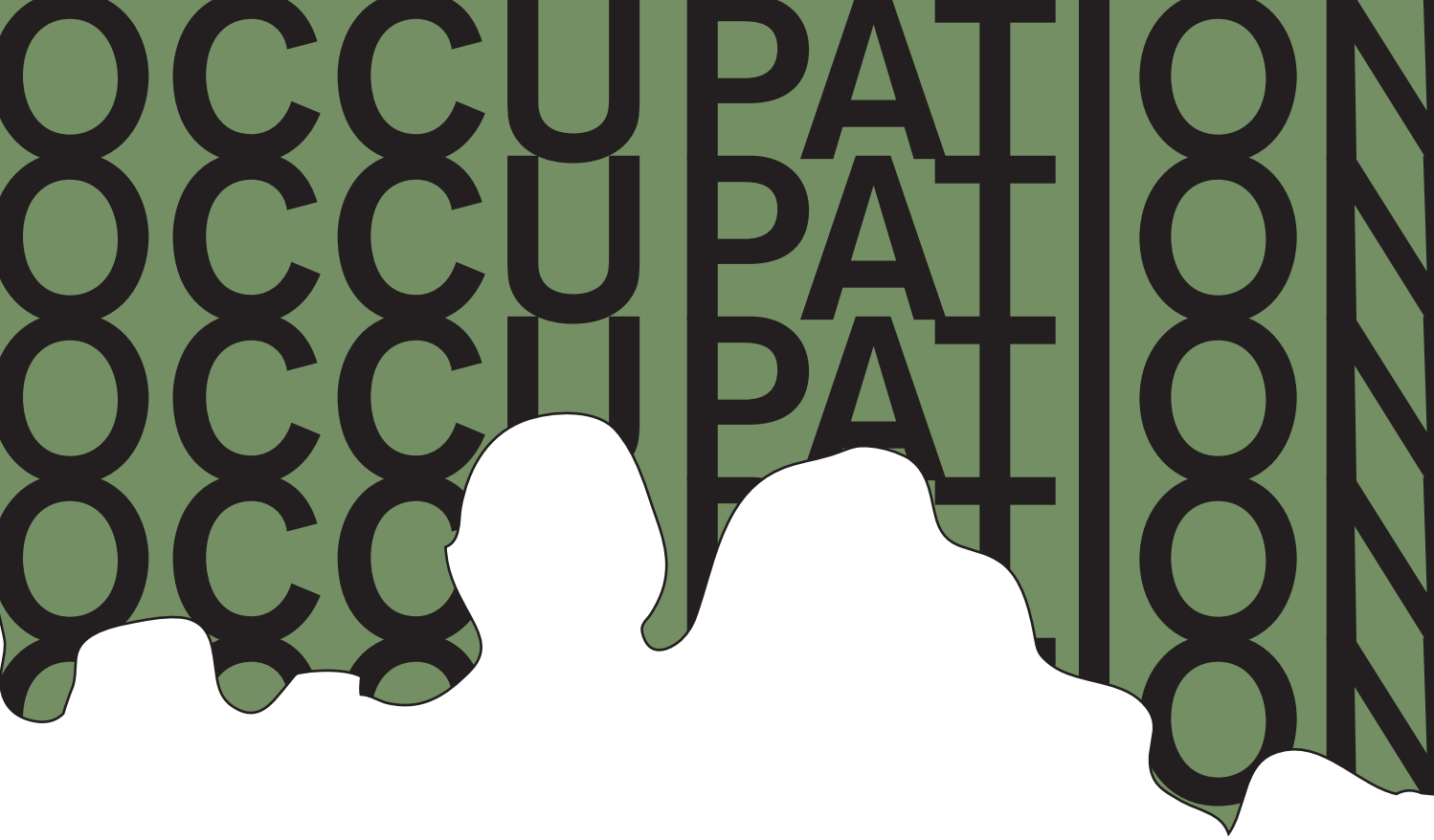
ON A TUESDAY evening in early September 2021, Karen DuBois-Walton '89 got a text from her friend Sarah Miller '03. Someone had been shot in their Fair Haven neighborhood in a parking lot just down the street from DuBois-Walton's home. DuBois-Walton rushed to the lot, meeting Miller and another friend and resident, Kica Matos. "There were a bunch of detectives and police just kind of standing around, and none of them were proactively engaging with the community," DuBois-Walton recalled. In an email interview, Miller said that was "the tipping point" for the three friends.

The parking lot where the shooting occurred has a long and well-documented history of illegal activity—much of the crime related to the adjacent bar, the Grand Cafe. Though the bar's owners have denied its involvement in illegal activity, several police reports and complaints of Fair Haven community members offer evidence to the contrary. The reports detail several instances of drug dealing and armed violence associated with the Cafe, and even reveal a discreet system by which bar employees sold cocaine to patrons.

2021 was a grim year for violent crime in New Haven and across the nation. That year, murders in the top American cities rose by 44 percent of their 2019 levels, with New Haven seeing 25 homicides and 110 non-fatal shootings. Fair Haven was especially hard hit, as six people were killed in the neighborhood. But, according to the *New Haven Independent*, the New Haven Police Department only made arrests in three of the city's murders. So when the September 7th shooting occurred, Matos said that DuBois-Walton, Miller, and herself "had a strong sense that the city had no plan or strategy in place to address the rising number of shootings - either in our neighborhood or the city."

So, drawing on their deep ties to the community, the three women left the crime scene and created a group chat to discuss ways to address the harmful activity in the parking lot themselves. DuBois-Walton was Mayor John DeStefano Jr.'s chief of staff and has been president of Elm City Communities, New Haven's public housing authority, for the past 14 years. In February, she was appointed as Chairperson of the Connecticut State Board of Education by Governor Ned Lamont. Matos worked as the deputy mayor of the city, was the president of Junta for Progressive Action, and now is a Vice President at the Vera Institute, an organization that advocates for criminal legal reform. Miller co-founded NHPS Advocates, a local education advocacy organization, and now serves Fair Haven as the Ward 14 Alder.

"We had been complaining about the lack of community policing, and it just all came to a head," explained DuBois-Walton. They organized a Community Management Team meeting—an opportunity for Fair Haven residents to gather to address problems in the neighborhood—and proposed an unconventional plan.



Residents would show up in the parking lot every day, three hours a day, for the next three weeks. According to Dubois-Walton, the goal was to "bring positivity, bring community, and just be a disruptor to what was happening out there." And many Fair Haveners, frustrated with New Haven's recent rise in violent crime, were on board.

ON SEPTEMBER 21ST, Bomba drums and lawn chairs in hand, the group of residents staked their claim on the parking lot, settling in for the hours ahead. Song and spoken word poetry filled the air as the sun set on the muggy mid-September day. Fair Haveners gathered, talked, laughed, and ate together. Alex Guzhnay, Ward 1 Alder and Fair Haven native, said that he saw "a lot of former neighbors and people I knew in the community, which goes to show how many locals supported the effort."

Some days had higher attendance and more participation than others but, according to DuBois-Walton, Fair Haveners were there every evening. The organizers coordinated entertainment and food for each night of the occupation, and as it started to gain media attention, they started receiving food donations and attracting participants from outside of the neighborhood. Ice the Beef — a local violence prevention organization — even arranged a march that culminated at the lot. During the occupation, organizers circulated a petition, which amassed nearly 300 signatures, to revoke the Grand Cafe's liquor license.

The results of the occupation were profound. "We built community and new optimism among neighbors that things can change," Miller said of the collective effort. According to Fair Haven District Manager Lieutenant Michael Fumiatti, who attended the occupation in uniform, the protest "absolutely" deterred crime and reduced police presence. "There were no major incidents in that corner or in the neighborhood during that period," claimed Miller, which DuBois-Walton and Matos corroborated.

The occupation also became a space for community building. Matos said that she herself "met new neighbors," and that "the lot ended up being a hub for community engagement." Fair Haven residents engaged in meaningful dialogue with one another, bar patrons, and the people who usually frequent the parking lot. DuBois-Walton said that those conversations allowed each group to find common ground and better understand each other. The occupation gave Fair Haven residents "clarity on what the community is really dealing with instead of relying on information from me," said Lieutenant Fumiatti, agreeing with DuBois-Walton. "When they can see with their own eyes," he added, "they can see what changes need to be made and what changes they need to advocate for to hopefully not even have to have the police there at all."

On February 3, the Connecticut Department of Consumer Protection denied the Grand Cafe's liquor license

“WE CHANGED WHAT IT FELT LIKE ON THAT CORNER, AND NO ONE LEFT IN HANDCUFFS.”

renewal request.

“We changed what it felt like on that corner, and no one left in handcuffs,” DuBois-Walton said.

THE DEBATE over crime and policing has taken an outsized role in New Haven politics, and this is the year where the city’s politicians will have to decide what they want public safety efforts to look like. With an increased Yale investment, American Rescue Plan Funding, and State PILOT funding, New Haven leaders are now faced with a question: what crime prevention strategies will they invest in? The current Connecticut General Assembly legislative session adds a tremendous sense of urgency to that decision, as New Haven has the opportunity to advocate for state funding to address crime and violence. Are efforts like the occupation — where community members are given the resources to mobilize to interrupt crime in their own neighborhoods — the ones the city should be investing in?

“It is certainly people-intensive,” Dubois-Walton said of the occupation. When asked if occupations like these were a long-term solution to crime in Fair Haven, Miller said, “No, of course not. It’s a short-term intervention to interrupt the negative trajectory, draw attention to the issue, and help shift things in a different direction.” That different direction, Matos says, is New Haven creating plans to reduce crime and significantly invest in Fair Haven.

DuBois-Walton argues that the strategic plans should lean on community policing and institutions that address the underlying causes of crime. She views the occupation as a model of collaboration between the community and police, saying “we can address the issues, address negative patterns, replace them with something positive, and do it in a way that offers resources to folks instead of just trying to throw them away or discard them.” Lieutenant Fumiatti’s views are similar. “If you understand what the community needs, then you can use the tools available to the police department to stick with the community’s mission on how they would like to be policed, and how they would like their neighborhoods and areas to look,” he said. “We might arrest a person, but I want my cops to understand what’s going on and find a way to plug that person into services that can get them out of the life of crime or get them out of a situation where they have to commit crimes in order to survive.”

Community violence intervention programs already exist in the nation’s top cities. Programs like Readi Chicago, Advance Peace, and Oakland Ceasefire send community members into their neighborhoods to engage with those most likely to be involved in gun violence, connecting them with mental health resources, job training, and other social services. But these programs’ short-term effects on crime are mixed, and many of them haven’t been tried on a large scale. Moreover, the investment these programs make are geared toward long-term change: they’re about building the kinds of institutions and community ties that can reshape neighborhoods over the course of a generation. That timeline is inconvenient for politicians facing the pressure of elections every few years and the communities suffering from crime right now.

It is unclear if New Haven will invest in this kind of community policing. Neither Mayor Justin Elicker nor the Interim New Haven Police Chief Renee Dominguez made an appearance at the occupation, which Matos called “shameful,” and the Elicker Administration has not publicly commented on the occupation. However, after securing $2 million in federal funding, the city seems poised to follow through on its plan to create a crisis-response team, which would deploy social services providers to address non-emergency 911 calls. On April 14th, Mayor Elicker announced a new gun violence prevention program, called PRESS, that would partner with several state and federal organizations to offer support to the formerly incarcerated and those most at risk of being involved in gun violence. But community members have expressed deep concern with the initiative’s reliance on police instead of existing community-run violence prevention programs.

Regardless of the direction the administration pursues, the occupation offers some powerful lessons. It demonstrates that community members can make their neighborhoods safer through small collective acts. It shows the power in infusing public spaces with positivity. And it suggests a perhaps radical idea: that we can counter violence with love and care instead of punishment and force.

Reflecting on the occupation, DuBois Walton said “The real success I think has been that the community came together, demonstrated its power, demonstrated its cohesion, worked effectively on something… and I think modeled for the city when community policing was working what it looked like.”

“We can do this in more and more places, and that’s what I hope can be long-lasting about this.”

YALE HYBRIDIZE NOW

BY **SARAH COOK**

Advocating for the Immunocompromised at Yale

AT THE START OF THE 2021-2022 SCHOOL YEAR, Katie Trumpener's colleagues in the Yale English Department were preparing to welcome students back to the classroom after more than a year on Zoom. But Trumpener, an immunocompromised professor, would be staying home. As she witnessed the return of in-person college life, Trumpener worried that the university was sacrificing the health and safety of its immunocompromised students and faculty in its rush to return to normalcy.

"The general push was to get everybody back," Trumpener said. "I have a fundamental philosophical difference." To her, "The top priority would be everybody getting through the pandemic alive. That's the bottom line."

Trumpener was not alone. After hundreds of Yale students went into COVID-19 isolation at the beginning of second semester, Julia Miranda '24 and priya v. '23 drafted a letter to Yale administrators, calling on them to provide hybrid learning options for students. They called their campaign "Yale Hybridize Now." Since February, their letter has received over 600 signatures from Yale community members and supporters from other universities. While the campaign has not yet

“The top priority would be everybod alive. That’s the bottom line.”

elicited substantial changes from the administration, advocacy for immunocompromised students continues at Yale and across the country as pandemic restrictions relax. This advocacy adds to work at Yale that began even before the pandemic to make learning more accessible.

On March 21, Yale joined a growing list of schools that partially lifted their indoor mask mandates. University Provost Scott Strobel announced that students must continue to wear masks in the classroom and instructional settings, healthcare facilities such as Yale Health, and campus transit vehicles, but not in gyms, libraries, or dining halls. Miranda, who is at high-risk for contracting severe symptoms from COVID-19, said these changes were “scary” for high-risk and immunocompromised students as it makes it harder to go about daily activities like going to the library.

To Abby Parrish ‘25, another immunocompromised student, the partial removal of the mask mandate after spring break represented a betrayal of Yale’s most vulnerable. The university capitulated to “healthy people clamoring for it to be lifted,” with a disregard for the “voices who did not feel ready.”

AS IT NAVIGATES THE RETURN TO IN-PERSON CLASSES, Yale has adapted its policies on masking, quarantining, and virtual learning throughout the school year as case counts and variants have risen and fallen. “We’re going to have to reinstitute masking or different testing strategies and responses every time there’s a variant that is going to cause substantial clinical disease,” Yale Assistant Professor of Medicine Sheela Shenoi told *The Politic.*

Shenoi predicted that Yale and other universities will move away from universal surveillance testing, and will soon move to a symptom-based testing plan. Still, she expects the infrastructure for testing to remain in place at Yale in order to “ramp down” and “ramp up” Yale’s testing capacity as needed based on case levels, new variants, and their severity.

However, Miranda said the uncertainty of constantly adapting public health measures to the pandemic’s feels “tumultuous,” and Parrish said that Yale’s current bi-weekly testing regime provides a huge comfort, given her at-risk status.

“I don’t like the idea of them lowering the number of times that people have to get tested,” Parrish said. “I understand that it’s an inconvenience; no one enjoys having to go get tested. But for the peace of mind that it provides, I think it is far more than worth it.”

Shenoi said she can “absolutely” understand why immunocompromised individuals are afraid given the loosened restrictions that Yale has already implemented. She emphasized that with Yale’s move to a mask-optional policy, it is important to cultivate spaces where a culture of mask-wearing is respected which can be accomplished by using language such as “mask-optional” in new policies.

Still, the partial removal of the mask mandate caused Parrish to revert back to some of her precautionary measures from the height of the pandemic. While Parish never felt safe in Yale’s dining halls to begin with as an immunocompromised student, she now actively avoids the most crowded dining halls because of the lack of masking in the crowded servery areas.

While there are still efforts from advocates to improve air filters and enforce high mask quality to make students feel safer in classrooms and other spaces, Miranda said the main focus of the current advocacy is bringing together faculty and student support for providing hybrid options for attending classes. In particular, advocates are working to provide a centralized system for students to request virtual accommodations.

“A more transparent policy that more clearly outlines the steps that immunocompromised students can take would [help] make sure that it’s not something that is up to their personal discretion,” Miranda told *The Politic.* “[It should be] part of a larger struggle for accessibility and disability justice.”

Miranda said a transparent policy to define the steps that students should take could have two components. First, undergraduate students seeking accommodations could request them through Student Accessibility Services (SAS), and graduate students could go through the Office of Institutional Access and Equity. There could also be a “governing structure” to notify professors of the need for accommodations for students who contract COVID-19 or are otherwise afraid of going to class, despite not being especially high-risk.

Parrish said that chronically ill and immunocompromised students are used to self-advocacy, and so most students would not see registering with SAS would not be seen as a huge barrier. However, Joaquin Lara Midkiff ’23,

ly getting through the pandemic

former president of Disability Empowerment for Yale (DEFY), told *The Politic* that registering through SAS would be "really hard on students." Instead, Midkiff said the conversation should focus on a "university consensus" around what learning looks like, rather than an individual-based approach in response to the needs of immunocompromised students. Trumpener identified another flaw with these policies: many immunocompromised people, including herself, do not see themselves as disabled, so they might not think to go through SAS to get accommodations as it is usually a resource used by disabled students.

"Faculty and teachers would benefit from a university-wide policy that encourages negotiating learning between faculty and students in a more open way," Midkiff said.

Parrish told *The Politic* that at the beginning of this semester, many of her professors offered remote options or recorded lectures, but now many of those options are being removed. Parrish feels these remote options provide peace of mind for immunocompromised students who do not feel safe in large classroom settings. Without them, it can be difficult for students to gauge how a professor may respond to requests for accommodations under the current vague, individualized system.

Trumpener pointed out that university guidelines have also limited choices for professors. Even when faculty want to teach online, they may not be able to.

Late in the summer of 2021, about a week before classes began, Trumpener received an email notifying her that she could fill out a form and obtain a doctor's note to get permission to teach remotely. However, she was "astonished" to find that with classes coming up, there was no medical committee formed to process her application. While Trumpener ultimately received approval to teach online, she said she knew other faculty members who lived with immunocompromised family members yet were not approved to teach remotely.

According to Trumpener, there are numerous faculty members who teach using a hybrid model without formal approval from Yale, with some professors resorting to Zoom when a student gets sick.

For Trumpener, the hybrid environment has been "pretty bumpy," but that has not dissuaded her from teaching remotely. However, she worries about what the future looks like if she is not able to return in-person in future semesters.

TO PARRISH, MIRANDA, AND MIDKIFF, their advocacy work in the context of the pandemic is part of a larger conversation about Yale's treatment of disabled and chronically ill students as a whole.

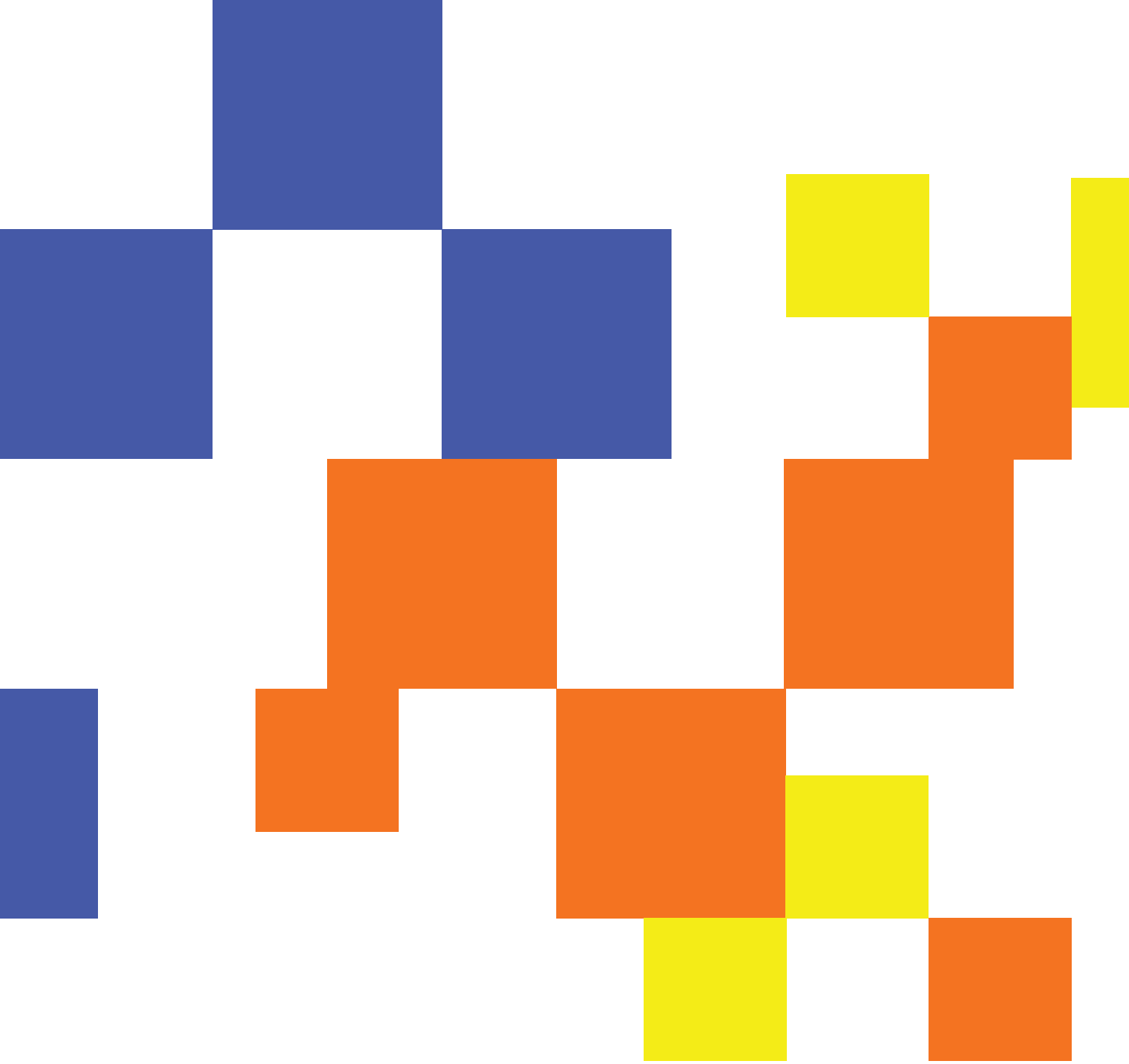
Before the pandemic, Midkiff said DEFY fought for flexible learning options for situations such as students who needed recovery from surgeries.

These ideas were "summarily rejected," but when the pandemic began, Yale quickly switched to online and hybrid options when they were needed for both non-disabled and disabled people. "All of a sudden [providing online learning] matters," said Midkiff. "This is an illustration of Yale not being particularly intelligent and proactive as an institution."

"I feel like the university has an opportunity as we look toward moving out of the pandemic to really center disabled and chronically ill voices and implement policies going forward as a whole that will benefit those groups," Parrish said.

Last summer, Midkiff pushed for the university to formalize hybrid learning options that included posting lecture recordings and having online office hours alternatives. To him, these options benefit all students. "Accessible education and access to spaces and places, benefits everybody, not just the people who they're ostensibly most directly serving, in this case, students with disabilities," Midkiff said.

DEFY was founded in 2016, but Midkiff pointed out that the membership has exploded in the last few years, occurring simultaneously with a "consciousness shift" at Yale where DEFY has led the conversation with a "large activism portfolio." As DEFY has expanded the conversation about accessible learning at Yale, Midkiff told *The Politic* he is hopeful that accessibility around learning can change, despite a lack of progress that resulted from advocates' efforts last summer. Especially as there is a new generation of faculty members and graduate students "intimately acquainted" with online learning, Midkiff and Miranda agreed there is reason to believe the many years of activism will finally provide accessibility in learning at Yale.



DELIAN ASPAROUHOV was an unlikely origin for an unlikely movement. An MIT dropout, he's worked for a little over three years at the venture capital firm Founders Fund, led by Peter Thiel and Keith Rabois—two deities of the tech world. Asparouhov, who in 2020 lived in San Francisco, was unconvinced that other U.S. cities could build up the venture capital and entrepreneurial infrastructure San Francisco had accumulated over decades. Thus, he was certain that the Bay Area would remain the undisputed heavyweight of tech. He viewed Miami (and a plethora of other cities touted as The Next Silicon Valley) as "more of a fad."

However, COVID-19 changed things around San Francisco. Strict lockdown policies and an explosion in remote work started to shrivel the city's geographic "ace in the hole": the fact that in the Bay Area, all the people in tech were physically together. Distancing measures and the nearly ubiquitous transfer to virtual meetings dramatically reduced this advantage.

But it wasn't the large-scale business restrictions that sparked the exodus to Miami. It was, instead, one simple irritant:

Delian Asparouhov could not eat outdoors.

ON A FRIDAY evening, December 6, 2020, Asparouhov discovered that San Francisco would lock down all outdoor dining in the city within 48 hours. A mix of confusion and annoyance struck him—after all, the city government had provided no proof indicating that outdoor dining caused the spread of COVID-19—and outdoor dining was one of Asparouhov's last remaining social outlets as he worked to incubate a new startup, Varda Space Industries, in one of America's most locked-down locales.

About 15 minutes after getting the news, Asparouhov fired off a tweet: "ok guys hear me out, what if we move

Heating Up

Miami's Tech Renaissance Takes Off

BY **JOHN WAHLIG**

silicon valley to miami." Speaking to *The Politic*, Asparouhov described the tweet as partially sarcastic. He was, at the time, still "relatively critical of the Miami movement." But the response Asparouhov got changed his perspective. Francis Suarez, the Mayor of Miami, retweeted Asparouhov's comment with a question: "How can I help?"

The mayor's reply catalyzed a tremendous positive response from individuals throughout the country's technology industry. Tech had found its public office champion after what some industry participants felt were years of neglect and even outright hostility by Bay Area officials. On one hand, tech leaders felt insulted by San Francisco's refusal to acknowledge their contributions to the city. One particularly salient example was in 2020, when the San Francisco Board of Supervisors voted to condemn the naming of the Zuckerberg San Francisco General Hospital and Trauma Center, due to its association with Mark Zuckerberg, noted founder of Meta née Facebook. Zuckerberg had donated $75 million to the hospital, and his reward appeared to be a slap in the face, courtesy of the San Francisco Board of Supervisors. On the other hand, wealthy tech entrepreneurs have increasingly faced steeper taxes—for example, San Francisco in 2020 approved an "Overpaid Executive Tax." These entrepreneurs have had a difficult time attracting labor in the high-regulation, high-living-cost environment of the Bay Area.

The tech workers involved in the Miami exodus, like Asparouhov, felt slighted by the anti-tech posture that they sensed within San Francisco city limits. But as for Miami, the technology community saw in the Mayor's tweet a sense of respectfulness and authenticity that seemed to be missing from the attitude of San Francisco officials. This "how can I help" tweet became the tagline of Miami's campaign to attract

tech firms, and embodied what the technology industry saw as a refreshing new attitude of receptiveness.

Asparouhov, the accidental origin of this new movement, reconsidered his "long SF" view. He mused that "perhaps Miami was the better place to build a really large tech community in the next decade." After the Mayor's tweet, Twitter and the news media outlets lit up, and the hype firestorm began. One *New York Times* article sensationally declared "Join Us in Miami! Love, Masters of the Universe." I, too, wrote an article on the nascent movement in April 2021, "Silicon Valley Hits the Beach." Today, a new set of questions has emerged. What continues to attract people to Miami — and how does Miami aim to sustain this growth? Do the government of Miami and the incoming technology firms still hold firm in their declaration of love? Or has their one-night stand come to an end?

KEVIN RUIZ is a Senior Advisor of Business Development & Recruitment at Venture Miami, an initiative that acts as a "concierge" between technology companies and Miami, hoping to attract tech firms by advertising the city's financial benefits and the promise of dedicated support for businesses.

Unlike the more recent spectators from the *New York Times* and the *Wall Street Journal*, Ruiz does not identify 2020 as the Miami tech movement's year zero. Instead, he emphasizes that Miami's resolve to attract technology firms started back in 2010. "A lot of people were building for a very long time, and I want to recognize that," Ruiz says. It was only after the foundation was firmly established that "Mayor Suarez's tweet . . . catalyzed everything."

Jose Vargas, co-founder and president of Healthcare.com, agrees. Vargas, originally from Venezuela, went to school in Miami and has remained in the city for 26 years—working in technology for 20 of those years. Vargas believes that Miami is the "center of the world" – it's within 6 hours of not only Silicon Valley on the West Coast, but also his own family in Europe and Latin America. Vargas also disagrees with the idea that Miami wasn't an entrepreneurial town before the recent movement—his previous five successful startups demonstrate that the ability to innovate in Miami has been present for years. According to Vargas, similarly to Ruiz's viewpoint, the tech growth in Miami has been a "slow change," recently accelerated. Vargas considers Miami's rise to prominence "a twenty-year overnight success."

Ruiz believes that part of this success is the way Miami makes their pitch to companies considering relocation. Miami's approach is vastly different from that of other major cities. "We try to have a conversation with someone," he affirmed. In many cases, when cities try to attract businesses, "people read off a deck and talk *at* someone. We talk *to* someone. We say, what are you interested in? Let's connect those dots for you." Ruiz also noted that his team is primed to connect new arrivals to all aspects of the community, business or otherwise—whatever is most important for them: offices, nonprofits, and schools are all aspects of Miami life that Ruiz can speak on.

In fact, despite the strong economic incentives for a move to Miami —with city sales tax at 7% (lower than New York City, San Francisco, and Chicago), and personal income tax and state corporate tax at 0% and 5.50%, respectively (lower than New York, California, and Illinois)—Ruiz remarked that very few people actually ask him about taxes. Rather, they are more interested in the Miami tech community.

Tech companies in San Francisco, after all, had been stomaching high tax rates for years, but tolerated it because of the ability to interact with the Bay Area's rich and dynamic community of peers. But once COVID measures they viewed as overly restrictive came into play, many in the tech industry were pushed over the edge. So, they went somewhere else to look for the network they so craved. Miami's response to COVID differed greatly from San Francisco. Although Miami-Dade County's COVID deaths per capita far outpace those in San Francisco, the area imposed far fewer restrictions on business and social interaction, allowing more connections to flourish. Ruiz makes it clear he believes that the main reason tech workers are moving to Miami is that "people are just looking for community, and for that receptive nature." While the low tax rates no doubt help attract companies hoping to pad their bottom line, Ruiz is convinced that Miami's ability to foster a sense of community in the midst of COVID, which San Francisco has struggled to do, is the main draw.

And Ruiz claims that new arrivals, no matter their origin, are destined to find a home in Miami. Ruiz told *The Politic* Miami doesn't "have to try to be inclusive . . . we just are." 58% of people living in the city are foreign-born, and 20% moved there from somewhere else domestically. What that variety of origin brings to Miami, Ruiz argued, is "a really good community of people who are motivated, that are open, that lend a helping hand – and that all ties together outside of tech, too." As Vargas relates from firsthand experience, "it feels like everybody's helping each other, and everybody feels part of a large and successful community."

Miami's tech community has been growing strong over the past year as the pandemic has faded. San Francisco, on the other hand, appears to be struggling to revive its network of technology workers. Companies like Meta and Google have only recently moved back into the office, and only in a hybrid format, at that. In contrast, tech companies in Miami, flying under Florida's more *laissez-faire* COVID approach, have had few, if any, interruptions to in-person work for over a year.

"HOW CAN I HELP" was not the beginning nor the end of Miami City Hall's efforts to grow the tech community in the Magic City. Jose Vargas told *The Politic* that Mayor Suarez is still working hard to generate buzz around Miami's technology industry. Vargas himself was in the Mayor's offices just a few weeks ago at one of Mayor Suarez's "Cafecito Talks" – conversations between the Mayor and members of the Miami community designed to spotlight businesses that are leading in Miami's tech ecosystem. It's a clever way for Miami to show both its citizens and the country at large that City Hall is serious about recognizing the technology community as a force for positive change. Other cities' politicians, like those in San Francisco, have been reluctant to open their doors to tech tycoons, whose agendas sometimes

"Do the government of Miami and the incoming technology firms still hold firm in their declaration of love? Or has their one-night stand come to an end?"

clash with those of elected officials. This includes, for instance, San Francisco's aforementioned restrictive approach to COVID regulations.

One of the recent San Francisco-Miami transplants, Zumper co-founder Taylor Glass-Moore, reflected, "It's very strange what happened in San Francisco . . . it's not just tech . . . [San Francisco's] politics are just anti-business." Yet despite his dissatisfaction, Glass-Moore never actually moved until the pandemic shut down the interactive entrepreneurial scene in San Francisco. When he decided to relocate, he found a great deal of support from Mayor Suarez's office on everything from office expansion discussions to hiring new employees. "The help was there. It was real," Glass-Moore said. "The Miami tech scene is here to stay. It's a rising tide that lifts all boats."

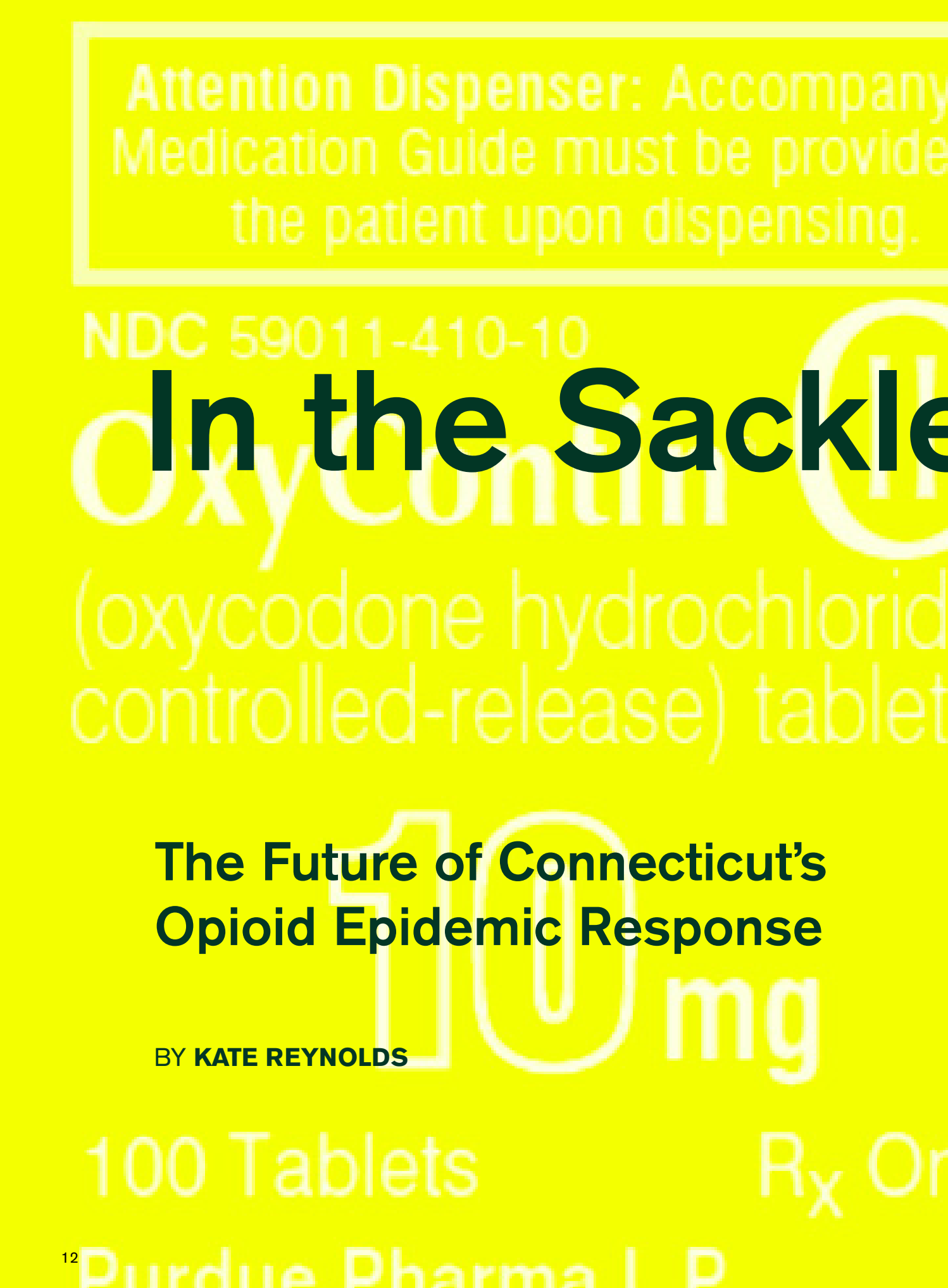
Whether this claim will hold up remains to be seen. As the "rising tide" phrase exemplifies, tech entrepreneurs who arrive in Miami feeling welcomed by the city often see more of the benefits their industry has to offer than its potential consequences. Of those in the tech industry interviewed, it was Jose Vargas, the 26-year Miami resident, who noted the "growing pains" wrought by the tech influx: traffic and the increase of real estate prices, for instance—new issues with which the local Miami populace has to grapple. The hope, though, is that the arrival of high-tech firms, along with the inflow of investment in these firms, will over time generate substantial net benefit for all of Miami's citizens.

DELIAN ASPAROUHOV, the initial Miami skeptic, believes that despite these "growing pains," Miami's future is bright. He can see the proof just looking out his office window, where he points out the dozens of cranes on the skyline. Compared to San Francisco, Asparouhov sees in Miami an "absolutely insane" rate of growth—one that strongly signals Miami will overcome the temporary hike in living costs, and that the city is evolving into a competitive hub of industry.

Even more important to Asparouhov than the physical differences between Miami and Silicon Valley are the contrasts in attitude, in city personality. Asparouhov paints a picture of Miami as a distinctly more pro-America, pro-capitalism region than his former home. "There was not a single American flag in my old neighborhood," Asparouhov muses, while in Miami, he sees red, white, and blue everywhere. People in Miami, according to Asparouhov, are "thrilled to be in a capitalistic, democratic republic." In contrast, he believes San Francisco has proven that it "isn't willing to grow with [the technology industry]," and thus has become disconnected from the spirit of free-market America. By Asparouhov's estimation, this capitalistic sentiment will greatly contribute to Miami's success—of course, it also creates an environment that stands to benefit the bottom line of entrepreneurs like Asparouhov, as well.

Mayor Francis Suarez, in an email to *The Politic*, spoke about City Hall's actions to ensure Miami's continued success alongside its burgeoning tech industry: "We've stuck to what we do best: keeping taxes low, funding our police, embracing innovation, investing in education, investing in quality of life." The Mayor believes last year marked the period in which Miami became widely accepted as a hub of technology. Meanwhile, he calls this year "the year of utility and adoption." Miami has, within the last year, become the new home of companies ranging from cryptocurrency startups to institutional investment firms. But, again, like Ruiz and Vargas, the Mayor notes that "this has been a 10 year process catalyzed by a confluence of factors we've all experienced throughout the last 2 years. We laid the foundation and put in the legwork and now it's about executing on the strategy we've envisioned." Asparouhov is grateful for the Mayor's supportiveness: "he speaks highly of tech, comes to our events, socializes and convinces people to move here," but aside from that, in line with the free-market paradigm, the Mayor "lets [the tech industry] do our job, and lets us build."

Two years ago, Delian Asparouhov dismissed Miami as a fad. It's been a long and unexpected journey for him, and many in the Miami tech community, since his tweet on a December evening in San Francisco. Today, Asparouhov is confident in Miami's future, and declared the Magic City shows "no signs of slowing down." In the Mayor's words, that is the ultimate goal: "making a Miami that lasts forever and a Miami that works for everyone."



In the Sackle

The Future of Connecticut's Opioid Epidemic Response

BY **KATE REYNOLDS**

ers' Backyard

LIZ FITZGERALD HAD BEEN waiting for this.

It was March 10th, 2022, and she suddenly found herself speaking before the family that had upended her life and robbed her of two children.

Fitzgerald has lost two sons to opioid addiction. Kyle, aged 25, died in 2013. Four years later, she lost his older brother, Matthew, when he was 32. Both Matt and Kyle were exposed to the prescription painkiller OxyContin while in high school and developed a years-long — and ultimately deadly — reliance on opioids.

Now, after years of fighting for justice for her sons, Fitzgerald had the chance to directly address the owners of the drug company that had pioneered OxyContin in the 1990s, lied about the painkiller's dangerously addictive effects, and sold it to millions of Americans.

"My oldest son said to me, 'You always said those Sacklers were going to know Matt and Kyle's names,'" Fitzgerald said in an interview with *The Politic*. "I always said it out of anger, that these Sacklers were going to know my kids. Who knew that I would have that opportunity?"

The opportunity to speak before the Sacklers was thanks to the $6 billion settlement that the family's company, Purdue Pharma, agreed to, constituting a massive payout to state governments and those impacted by America's devastating opioid crisis. Liz lives in Southington, Connecticut, a small town about an hour's drive from Purdue Pharma's Stamford headquarters. "[Connecticut Attorney General William Tong] asked me, 'Would you want to confront the Sacklers?' I said, absolutely."

The deal will give Connecticut approximately $95 million over 18 years to invest in solutions to the opioid crisis and help victims of opioid use disorder. There is no shortage of need for these additional funds: a cri-

Fitzgerald recalled being asked b announced if she thought the Sa absolutely not. The $6 billion is fo

sis that began in the 1990s has shown no sign of stopping, with Connecticut experiencing a 500% increase in opioid overdoses since 2010. In 2020, the state witnessed nearly 1,400 deaths due to opioid overdoses. The problem is worst in Yale's own backyard, with New Haven County accounting for a quarter of the state's overdose deaths.

Considering how to spend the millions of dollars won in the Sackler lawsuit has forced Connecticut into a reckoning with its opioid epidemic. Overdoses continue to rise, even as the funding and research available to counter them has also increased. This contradiction begs consideration of what has gone wrong in the state's tackling of the crisis, and what can be done to correct the course.

PURDUE PHARMA BILLED ITSELF as "a pioneer in developing medications for reducing pain." Its central product, the painkilling drug OxyContin, was released in 1995. The sole active ingredient is oxycodone, an opioid twice as strong as morphine, and the drug's potency represented an exciting opportunity for Purdue to capitalize on relieving extreme pain and discomfort. The company quickly launched an intense marketing campaign to convince doctors to prescribe the medication to patients. Purdue's lobbying proved shockingly successful: since its release, OxyContin has generated over $35 billion in revenue for Purdue. The United States is now the world's largest consumer of opioid medications and is responsible for 80% of global prescriptions for opioid painkillers.

What Purdue's marketing campaign conveniently omitted was how addictive OxyContin is. Their advertising targeted doctors, using the results of company-funded studies to prove that overreliance on the painkiller would not be a problem. Purdue executives promised the drug's relief would last 12 hours, but an investigation by the Los Angeles Times concluded that the company knew that the effects wore off hours earlier for most people, forcing users to take the pills with increasing frequency. A report by the Department of Justice concluded that Purdue executives knew about drug users crushing and snorting OxyContin as early as 1996, yet testified for years that they had not been alerted to the drug's risks until 2000. Even after a 2007 lawsuit concluded that the company's leadership had misled doctors and patients about the drug's harms, Purdue continued to sell prescription painkillers and aggressively rebut allegations of a cover-up.

The result of this relentless pill-pushing has been catastrophic. More than one in every five patients who are prescribed opioids will eventually misuse them. Thousands of Americans who were given OxyContin — often only for minor discomfort — suddenly found themselves battling a reliance on the drug. And when prescriptions expired or grew too expensive to maintain, many people struggling with their medicine's addictive effects turned to more serious opioids like heroin instead. Both Kyle and Matt began using opioids with OxyContin; Kyle was prescribed it for an injury, and Matt was given it by a friend. "That was the start of their full-blown addiction," said Fitzgerald. "When they couldn't get the pill, it turned into heroin… And then it just became a life of hell." Matt and Kyle were not alone: one study concluded that four out of every five people who try heroin started with prescription painkillers.

The opioid crisis grew even worse in the early 2010s when fentanyl, a synthetic opioid that is much stronger than heroin and reserved normally for excruciating pain, began flooding the black market. The combination of fentanyl with heroin was a toxic mix. Connecticut experienced a 400% increase in opioid overdose deaths from 2013 to 2016, largely driven by increasing rates of heroin and fentanyl abuse. Many people with opioid use disorder did not even realize that fentanyl was in their drug supply: some dealers secretly mix fentanyl into their heroin or other synthetic opioids because it is much cheaper to manufacture, and its effects are much stronger. Just a small amount of fentanyl can be deadly, especially if the user is unaware of its presence. Fitzgerald attributes Matt's death to fentanyl, which was in the drugs he took without his knowledge. Matt's daughter recently asked Fitzgerald about her father's death. "Your dad was poisoned," Fitzgerald told her.

Matt and Kyle constitute two of the nearly half a million people in the U.S. who died from using prescription or illicit opioids from 1999 to 2019. Overdose and death rates have been increasing even as the rate of prescriptions for painkillers like OxyContin have been decreasing, demonstrating how Purdue Pharma's "blockbuster" drug has effects reaching far beyond its

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initial campaign. "[Matt] never knew in a million years that one pill would be the demise of his life," said Fitzgerald. Now, countless families like the Fitzgeralds have to suffer the consequences.

IN SEPTEMBER 2021, New York federal judge Robert Drain announced that he had approved a bankruptcy deal with the Sacklers. The family would give up control of Purdue Pharma, declare bankruptcy, and pay $4.3 billion over nine years to the plaintiffs in thousands of lawsuits. This money would be funneled mainly into two funds: one for compensating victims, and another for investing in states' opioid crisis responses. In exchange, the Sacklers would be totally immune from all future criminal and civil lawsuits.

The same day the deal was approved, nine states and a handful of cities declared their intention to oppose it. Connecticut Attorney General William Tong led the fight. "This decision is a slap in the face to the millions of suffering and grieving Americans who have lost their lives and loved ones due to the Sacklers' calculated and craven pursuit of opioid profits," he said at a press conference. Tong vowed to press forth, and hold the family further accountable. And press forth he did: On March 3rd, Tong's office announced that it and the Attorney Generals from the other states who had sued had reached a new deal with the Sacklers. The settlement was now worth $6 billion, and while the Sacklers would still be immune from all civil claims, Tong had ensured they remained vulnerable to criminal prosecutions.

Liz Fitzgerald was sitting by Tong's side as he outlined the new settlement at a press conference. "Other states were folding and caving the more money [the Sacklers] threw at them," Fitzgerald said. "But [Attorney General Tong] really wanted justice… And I know he fought as hard as he could for as long as he could." Both Fitzgerald and Tong expressed that the deal was inadequate, with Tong lamenting that he did not win even more money. Fitzgerald recalled being asked by a friend after the deal was announced if she thought the Sacklers were remorseful. "I said, absolutely not. The $6 billion is for the parents to go away."

Under the terms of the settlement, the Sacklers were required to apologize to the nation and attend a hearing where those affected by the opioid crisis could testify about their struggles. The hearing occurred on March 9th, over Zoom, and featured 28 speakers. Some of those who testified were formerly addicted to opioids. But most were like Fitzgerald, victims of witnessing someone else's addiction, people who spoke of the horror of watching their loved ones grow reliant on opioids. Richard Sackler, the former president and chairman of Purdue Pharma and one of three members of the family who attended the call, had his camera turned off. So Fitzgerald was forced to tell a black box about the lives OxyContin had ruined, including her own. "I didn't feel any vindication," she said about testifying. "But I just felt like I had to… let them know the pain they caused. Not just my family, but the nation."

The results of the settlement negotiated by Tong could be revolutionary. About $750 million of the $6 billion will go to victims and family members; the rest will go to state, local, and some tribal governments. Connecticut will receive about $95 million from the deal. This whopping number is not even the largest settlement that the state is receiving for opioid assistance. In February 2022, the drug manufacturer Johnson & Johnson and some smaller distributors were compelled to pay $26 billion to victims and states; Connecticut will begin to receive payments of its $300 million share of this deal in July. This money is eagerly anticipated by experts, advocates, and those touched by the crisis. But it also poses a challenge: although experts today largely agree on the most effective ways to combat opioid use disorder, the state's response has not always reflected these methods. The way that the settlement money is used may be an opportunity to improve this.

CONNECTICUT ATTEMPTED TO act against the opioid crisis relatively early. It was one of the earliest states in the nation to provide immunity to those who call for help during a drug overdose; to implement a drug take-back program where residents could dispose of unwanted prescription drugs; to create a database enabling physicians to check patients' history with painkillers; to coordinate a public campaign emphasizing the harms of opioid use; to increase penalties for selling fentanyl. But these actions were largely uncoordinated and representative of the state's desperate attempts to try whatever it could to combat ris-

ing overdoses, a piecemeal approach that undermined Connecticut's ability to respond in the most effective ways. More fundamentally, the initial state response represented a traditional focus on preventing rather than treating addition. Dr. Robert Heimer, a Professor of Epidemiology at the Yale School of Public Health and infectious diseases expert, explained in an interview with *The Politic* that this original focus on prevention reflected the larger tendency of governments to attempt to stop drug use altogether, rather than attempting to stop it from becoming deadly.

As the crisis deepened, medical experts began to emphasize the need for new forms of treatment for substance abuse. Their research concluded that attempting to prevent drug use through abstinence programs or public campaigns about the dangers of substance abuse did not work. Instead, this research found, the state should prioritize harm reduction, an approach that addresses addiction as it occurs and aims at managing the negative effects of substance abuse.

Yale researchers were at the forefront of this work. In 1970, faculty of the Yale School of Medicine founded the APT Foundation, one of the first organizations in the country to use synthetic medications to treat opioid disorder. APT established some of New Haven's earliest locations offering methadone and buprenorphine, medications that simulate the effects of opioids without the addictive qualities, and naloxone, a medication that undoes opioid overdoses. In 2015, faculty at the Yale School of Medicine conducted the first-ever randomized trial to compare the effectiveness of buprenorphine treatment with the state's traditional approach, and found that giving patients buprenorphine made them twice as likely to engage in treatment. Yale received a federal grant to implement the study's recommendations and funded buprenorphine pilot programs at four other hospitals across the nation.

Harm reduction research in Connecticut culminated with a groundbreaking effort authorized by then-Governor Daniel Malloy in 2016. Malloy tasked a team of Yale medical experts including Dr. Heimer to partner with the state's Alcohol and Drug Policy Council and write the Connecticut Opioid Response (CORE) plan. It outlined six research-tested strategies for the state to address the opioid crisis. These included some logistical reforms, like encouraging state agencies to improve data-sharing, and programmatic ones that called for harm reduction to become the framework for the state's response. These programmatic recommendations included increasing access to naloxone, using methadone and buprenorphine as treatment, and allowing for spaces for safe drug use and syringe exchanges.

Nancy Navarretta, the Commissioner of the state's Department of Mental Health and Addiction Services (DMHAS), told *The Politic* that the state's approach has been changing, partly in response to this research. "It's really important to invest more in harm reduction strategies, so we have been pivoting in that direction... Our focus has really shifted to keep people alive," Navaretta said. The state now helps fund centers that offer clean syringes and fentanyl strips; it supports the use of the naloxone drug to combat overdoses; it has allowed for spaces where people can safely use drugs. In 2016, the government started sending Yale doctors into hospitals across the state to teach physicians how to administer methadone and buprenorphine for treatment.

In spite of Connecticut's increased focus on harm reduction techniques, the state's response has continued to prove inadequate in the face of an enduring epidemic. "Despite us knowing what to do, the numbers keep getting worse," said Dr. Fiellin, one of the CORE authors, in an interview with the health news website CT Health I-Team. There were over 1,500 fatal drug overdoses in Connecticut in 2021, a number that has been increasing every year. Fentanyl has been driving this worrying trend, with one study concluding that fentanyl-related overdose deaths in the state increased fifty-fold between 2012 and 2018. Overall, Connecticut residents are more likely to die from a drug overdose than from a car accident, homicide, the flu, diabetes, or kidney disease.

PART OF THE REASON WHY Connecticut's shift towards harm reduction techniques has not succeeded in reducing overdoses is because this shift has not been adequately backed up by large-scale investments or legitimate involvement. Connecticut has left the actual implementation of the state's response to non-state actors rather than local and state institutions. All of the methadone clinics advertised on the Connecticut state website, for instance, are run by non-governmental agencies. This decision reflects the state's understanding that the community organizations who have the most face-to-face interaction with residents who abuse opioids are better-suited to support their recovery and monitor their treatment's success. "We have a system of both for-profit and nonprofit agencies that are actually doing the healthcare and social service work for the state, with state money," said Heimer.

But the gap left by the government's lack of leadership has not been

filled with adequate funding for the groups that actually implement Connecticut's harm reduction programs. Spending on programs to combat substance abuse is a tiny fraction of the state budget. Staff of the state Department of Mental Health and Addiction Services have staged large protests multiple times over the few years, demanding increased funding. Their advocacy has rarely succeeded. In the absence of state money, organizations have turned to other funding sources, primarily the federal government's grants, like the Center for Disease Control and Prevention's State Opioid Response Grant. From 2018 to 2020, Connecticut received over $18 million each year from a federal substance abuse grant; less than $250,000 was spent every year on methadone treatment programs. Using the cost calculations from a 2017 study, these funds would cover a year of treatment for only 53 people.

Connecticut's current system gives community organizations the responsibility for the response but not the necessary funding, which renders the state government's embrace of harm reduction largely symbolic. The critical steps the CORE plan called for — a plan authorized by the government itself — have largely been ignored, despite then-candidate Lamont's espousal of support for CORE in his 2018 race. During the election, Lamont also promised to appoint a state "drug czar" to handle Connecticut's response to the opioid epidemic; after taking office, no such position was created. Thus, even as the state proclaims its support for innovative new approaches to the crisis, its rhetoric has largely proved hollow. Steve Werlin leads the Downtown Evening Soup Kitchen (DESK), a service group that provides assistance to unhoused and vulnerable residents of New Haven. Werlin explained that the state government's policies allow DESK to keep naloxone at its physical locations, but the group receives the medication as a donation from another organization. "[State and local governments] are supportive in the sense that they have said they're supportive of harm reduction approaches," he said about DESK's relationship with the state. "But at the end of the day, funding for that naloxone is primarily coming from other places."

For years, the state attributed its underinvestment in addiction services to chronic budgetary shortages. Money from the settlements with companies like Purdue Pharma and Johnson & Johnson provides an opportunity to fund the programs that state officials have rhetorically embraced. Indeed, the plan put forth by Governor Ned Lamont in February 2022 for the hundreds of millions of dollars Connecticut won from the Johnson & Johnson lawsuit mentioned using the money on harm reduction.

BUT THE FAILURE by some local and state officials in Connecticut to implement a robust response to the opioid epidemic may not just be a result of insufficient investment in harm-reduction techniques. Rather, some activists have labeled it the result of a fundamental misunderstanding of the crisis, one that overlooks the crucial role that mental health plays in opioid use disorder. Advocates continually emphasize that substance abuse often occurs with, or results from, mental health issues. Jason Bokowski, a public relations representative from New Haven's Narcotics Anonymous group, has seen the intersection of these two crises upclose, at NA meetings. "A very high percentage of the addicts are diagnosed. They're not just suffering from drug addiction," Bokowski said, who is in recovery from drug addiction.

Scientific research has confirmed this fact time and time again: adults with mental health disorders are significantly more likely to abuse opioids.

Connecticut residents are more likely to die from a drug overdose than from a car accident, homicide, the flu, diabetes, or kidney disease.

"We have all these detoxes and rehabs but they don't address the mental health aspect," said Bokowski. "I definitely believe there should be more emphasis placed on the mental health part." One 2013 study concluded that four in every ten young Americans with a serious mental health condition also had a substance use disorder. But despite the intimate ties between opioid use and mental health, behavioral health programs have often separated treatment for drug abuse disorder from treatment for mental disorders. "We have to stop thinking of healthcare as medical care, and have to start thinking of healthcare as wellness," said Heimer. For Connecticut to fully overcome its opioid epidemic demands attention to the trauma that often undergirds addiction; without addressing these issues, overdoses and deaths appear likely to continue to rise.

Both Kyle and Matt Fitzgerald suffered from mental disorders that made their experimentation with OxyContin in high school more risky. "Mental health issues came before the addiction," Liz Fitzgerald said. "That's important to know, because a lot of the time in substance abuse, they are trying to treat the addiction and not really treating the cause." She described the difficulties her sons faced while managing mental health problems and opioid addiction: they often encountered stigma from medical professionals, who believed they could not get better or failed to account for their mental health problems while treating them.

John Labieniec, who works at Continuum of Care CT, a nonprofit dedicated to supporting those struggling with or recovering from opioid addiction in New Haven, shares this concern. Labienic is in recovery, and expressed frustration with the short-term approach that many advocates and officials have traditionally taken towards addressing drug abuse. "Treatment centers are based on a 30-day model… treatment from addiction doesn't end in 30 days," he said. "To think that people are going to be fixed in 30 days? It's just absurd." Fitzgerald also witnessed the shortfalls of this treatment model through her son Matt's experiences. He was often placed into intensive care facilities, but they rarely worked. "Matt was admitted to six facilities in one week," Fitzgerald said. "So yes, I have an issue with the fact that mental health is not treated like medical health." As Connecticut weighs how to spend the money it is set to receive from high-profile lawsuits against pharmaceutical companies, the solution may not lie in an expansion of existing programs but in a total transformation of the state's response.

Frustrated by the inadequate mental and substance abuse support both of her sons had received, Fitzgerald became inspired to fight for improvements to the way that America understands and approaches substance abuse. She joined the board of Tri-Circle, a nonprofit organization that provides counseling to those affected by addiction disorders, whether personally or by a loved one's affliction. When she was debating if she should get involved in substance abuse advocacy, this concern with mental health loomed large, and she made sure to ask the director of Tri-Circle what the organization's vision for treatment was before joining. Her eagerness to fix the healthcare system is always grounded in the loss of her two sons. "I have 15 years of stories. That's why I feel things need to be changed," Fitzgerald said. "More people just need to keep on pushing and pushing and pushing, and somebody's going to listen. Somebody, hopefully, is going to do their job."

"To think that people are going to be fixed in 30 days? It's just absurd."

A NEW COURSE

Germany's Pivot on Energy and Security

BY **AXEL DE VERNOU**

FOR THE PAST TWO DECADES, Germany's ship of state has calmly charted a straight, undisturbed path. In the wake of Russia's invasion of Ukraine, an unexpected gust of wind has struck Berlin's sails and the ship is abruptly tacking in a new direction. A steadfast supporter of the principles of sovereignty, peaceful dispute settlement, and democratic ideals that define the North Atlantic Treaty Organization, the European powerhouse could no longer stand by as soldiers leveled buildings about 932 miles from its capital. With a population eager to respond to the conflict, but a government that is aware of the long-term security and economic vulnerabilities that come with such a pivot, Germany has now decided to detach itself from Russian oil and gas while revolutionizing its industry and military might. These sweeping transformations are here to stay.

While Europe's leadership felt divided at the beginning of the crisis and had an unsynchronized response to Russia's troop build-up, unity came swiftly after the invasion. European powers have rallied together in the past few months to demonstrate solidarity for Ukraine by sending military aid and heavily sanctioning Russia. Unfortunately, in doing so, they are all engaging in a delicate balancing act, some more than others. In the effort to cut all ties with Russia as a response to the Kremlin's unspeakable acts in Ukraine, European countries are absorbing significant blows to their economy, which risks destabilization and citizen unrest.

TRAPPED IN RUSSIA'S WEB

Blessed with an advantageous geographical terrain that has endowed it with a wealth of natural resources, Russia has gradually locked European partners in an inescapable partnership by heavily prioritizing energy exports to the continent. With 17 billion tons of oil and 48 billion cubic meters of gas in its reserves, Russia dominates the domestic production of its European neighbors and has historically been willing to profit from this imbalanced relationship. In the 1970s and 1990s, Russia constructed two significant pipelines running through Eastern European countries to continue leveraging their influence, dodging American resistance along the way. In the 1960s, Europe's importation of Russian gas and oil was in the single digits. It now reaches a staggering 60%.

Indeed, after 2010, Europe's natural gas production fell precipitously as it came to rely on Russia for its essential imports while opting for a shift to alternative sources of energy in the long run. As a result, many countries overlooked Russia's incursions in Eastern Europe in 2008 and 2014 because of the mutually beneficial economic exchange— houses were heated, tanks were filled, and industries were powered in Europe while Russia's pockets were filled. Nonetheless, the integral role that Russian resources played for the wellbeing and survival of European citizens made the relationship precarious from the beginning. Germany is perhaps the most striking example of a European country that has been forced to come to terms with its entrenched dependence.

Germany is perhaps the most striking has been forced to come to terms

In 2021, Germany received more than half of its natural gas and about a third of its oil from Russia. Consequently, the detachment process will affect practically every citizen and have a monumental impact on its economic foundations. "You have to take a gradual approach," Julian Mueller-Kaler, a resident senior fellow at the Atlantic Council's GeoTech Center, told *The Politic*. "Weaning an economy the size and importance of Germany off gas and oil from Russia overnight is counterproductive." Despite the country's willingness to come to Ukraine's defense, the economic ramifications that come with swift action, including high inflation rates, have led to a divergence between what the government says and does. A public opinion poll conducted by public broadcaster ZDF highlighted that 55% of Germans favor an embargo, but the government, fearing a devastating recession, has been unwilling to take such a dramatic measure.

"Decisions will be heavily… but not completely influenced by public opinion," said Tyson Barker, the head of the Technology and Global Affairs Program at the Council on German Relations. There are "some concerns as to whether or not the German public is aware of the kind of sacrifices that will be required" to completely divest from Russian resources. This is because Germany is entering another era of *Wendepolitik*; literally, politics of the shift.

DISENTANGLEMENT AND COMMUNICATION

Barker enumerated a series of transformational "u-turns" that Germany has taken in its history which can be compared to today's energy and military shift. They include Germany's rapid reunification in 1989-1990, the country's sudden announcement that it would be shifting away from nuclear power after the 2011 Fukushima incident, sectoral sanctions against Russia in 2014, Chancellor Merkel's decision to open the country to a massive flow of refugees in 2015, and finally, the euroization of an investment stimulus package in 2020 following the outbreak of the pandemic. "Germans tend not to reverse positions once they have made a commitment," said Barker. The changes being witnessed

today are most likely here to stay.

Germany will also need to address weak communication between its leadership and the general population if it intends to keep public opinion high. Dr. Stormy-Annika Mildner, the Executive Director of the Aspen Institute Germany, emphasized the crucial role that communication plays in such a crisis. "There needs to be even more information on what could happen to prices in the medium to long run when the war continues and how the government is going to react to this," she said. Mildner was also a Fox

g example of a European country that
s with its entrenched dependence.

International Fellow at Yale University.

This exchange of economic indicators and future projections is a "fine line to walk," according to Mildner. On the one hand, the more the government promotes transparency about rising prices, the higher the probability that consumers panic and buy lots of goods in the short term. On the other hand, keeping communications opaque can leave citizens disillusioned about the steps that the Economic Ministry and other committees are taking to alleviate pressure.

Germany's reckoning of an unhealthy dependence on Russia resources has forced the country to reconsider how it wants to tackle a green energy revolution. Before the invasion, Germany established a set of noble benchmarks to phase out its emission of greenhouse gasses until 2045, targeting a 65% and 88% reduction in 2030 and 2040, respectively, compared to 1990 levels. Although its success in meeting these goals is expected to be subpar, according to an August 2021 draft government report, key members in the Bundestag, Germany's parliament, have been pioneering serious climate reform to stay on track with proposed environmental reform. Moreover, following the nuclear accident in Fukushima, Germany also promised to shut down all of its nuclear power plants by the end of 2022.

These initiatives were widely praised by German citizens before resources became scarce. Now, there has been talk of reneging on these commitments so that Germany can become energy independent before aspiring to environmental friendliness. "I think that you [will] probably see a compromise on climate goals," Jörn Fleck, deputy director with the Europe Center at the Atlantic Council, told *The Politic*. This is because resource independence from Russia will need to happen quickly, and green energy goals were planned for multiple decades from now.

A FEW STEPS BACK

One immediate reaction to rising energy prices was to propose delaying the shutdown of Germany's three remaining nuclear plants. Unfortunately for Germany, the process is not so simple. A 2017 deal decommissioned the factories' funds to a public trust and it would be difficult to reserve this decision. For the past few years, operators in the final three plants have completely focused their energy on shutting them down and many have expressed discontent with the German government's sudden policy shift. Mueller-Kaler also pointed to "significant risks in terms of reactor securities" which would impede this reversal. He believes that these complications mean that Germany will instead opt for "restructuring [its] energy sector."

The country has turned in various directions to successfully execute this transition, recognizing that it may have to walk back on environmental ambitions. Germany is accelerating the construction of liquified natural gas (LNG) terminals connected to the United States and other suppliers to wean itself off Russian gas more quickly, according to Fleck. Coal-burning processes previously viewed as unhealthy for the environment are restarting. Berlin has also attempted to strengthen rapprochement with Middle Eastern countries to divest from Russian oil. In March 2022, Germany forged an energy deal with Qatar after the Minister of Economic Affairs visited Doha.

All three of these initiatives will help Germany acquire enough energy to last through the end of the year in the event that it completely detaches itself from Russia. Noble environmental legislation will presumably return to the table after the worst of the economic pain is over.

These partnerships have also been helpful for integrating renewable forms of energy into the economy. For instance, Germany and Saudi Arabia agreed in the same month to cooperate on the production and importation of hydrogen by using renewable power through a process called electrolysis.

Caught unprepared in its energy a
ship is back on course and beg
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Not only would this represent a success for renewable energy in Germany since hydrogen does not emit nearly the same quantity of greenhouse gasses as burning coal, for example, but it is also an example of strategic international cooperation.

The recent accord with Saudi Arabia represents an ideal scenario for Germany: attentiveness to renewable energy, reinforced ties with a country to acquire indispensable resources, and the further erosion of Russian ties. This balance is difficult to strike, and Germany's reciprocity with a country like Saudi Arabia is not guaranteed to persevere in the long run. "I think this can only be a short term thing," said Mueller-Kaler, explaining that collaborating with Middle Eastern countries is a "transitory, stop-gap measure that has to be taken" to mitigate the vertiginous rise in prices.

Like many other European countries and the United States, Germany will have to prudently thread the needle between long-term environmentally conscious policy and immediate responses to the Kremlin's war crimes. Proponents of these policies, especially within Germany's Green Party, "will have to take a really hard look at their ideas of energy policy and a green transition in the short-term," according to Mueller-Kaler. Wind and solar electric systems could not keep an industry-heavy country like Germany afloat if it chose to completely cut ties with Russia. Thus, the crisis in Eastern Europe will force German leaders to juggle climate goals, economic ties to Russia, and support for Ukraine at the same time.

THE SECOND MAJOR SHIFT: DEFENSE

Instead of keeping all hands off the ropes, Germany's ship of state will need to establish a clear sense of direction in the coming years. Despite its remarkable economic preponderance in the European balance of power, Germany has absolutely failed militarily during the post WWII years of relative international peace. Berlin's armed forces have been left to atrophy due to few exterior threats and exceptionally low defense spending, and strategic calculations have been absent from German discourse for all too many decades.

Such an assessment can be drawn by comparing Germany's military expenditure to other countries and following the divergence between its economic growth and defense spending since its reunification in 1871. Between 1871 and 1912, German military expenditure as a share of GDP hovered around 2-3%. When WWI and WWII ravaged Europe, spending shot up considerably. After an abrupt decline in 1945 at the conclusion of the conflict and a gradual downward path, Germany's defense spending returned to its post-war level in the 1980s, but did not stop there. For the past two decades, it has barely exceeded 1%.

While less expenditure in this industry may initially seem like an indication of beneficent intentions, Germany did not fall in line with the requirements it had to fulfill as a part of NATO. In 2006, members of the organization agreed that they would dedicate a minimum of 2% of their GDP to defense spending for military vigilance by 2024, a recommendation which Germany ignored for 15 years. The striking dimension of its inferior military spending becomes obvious when one looks at the country's formidable GDP growth since the reunification. The GDP per capita has dramatically increased since 1871, highlighting how its current spending is exceptionally low compared to its neighbors. Indeed, despite all having smaller economies, Romania, Estonia, Latvia, Poland, Lithuania, France, Norway, and Greece all met NATO's 2% requirement in 2020 while Germany left its military to decay before the invasion.

Three days after Russian forces entered Ukraine, the German ship of state finally recognized that prioritizing military and strategic capabilities is indispensable in a world where territorial encroachment and neglect for a rules-based international order are still prevalent. Chancellor Olaf Scholz announced on February 27 of this year that Germany would raise its defense spending to above 2% of its GDP as soon as possible to fortify German and European security.

At the heart of Germany's recent initiatives to provide aid to Ukraine and offer a more definitive defense to the Kremlin is its objective to assume a "security and defense role that is more commensurate with its economic weight," according to Rathke. "Some people have talked about Europe as being an economic superpower and a strategic dwarf. You can apply the same description to Germany." With such an enormous amount of money being funneled into spending projects, Germany clearly hopes to undergo a long-term, structural shift to replace its enfeebled image within the European alliance.

and military strategy, the German inning a transformative process or power in the coming years.

Although the announcement is yet another monumental example of Germany's *Wendepolitik*, a turn in its history marked by a significant event, the reality is that this transformation will be incremental and multidimensional. "It's not off the shelf stock," Mueller-Kaler explained, noting that the types of material that Germany is planning to buy will be delivered at the end of the decade. According to Mueller-Kaler, there will be "changes in procurement policy at every stage— at the supplier stage and the demand stage."

The revolutionary nature of this shift will open the door to fresh discussions about a centralized European strategy, a topic of conversation that has been absent in international discourse for quite some time. For example, according to Fleck, there has been a debate driven principally by France about how Europe should become more independent from the U.S. Germany, with its increased military spending, new leadership, and improved capabilities, could help lead Europe in an effort to "create greater European security and defense capacities," said Fleck. However, Fleck stressed that for Berlin, a "European security architecture" would always include a transatlantic dimension linked closely to the United States and would differ from French conceptions of "strategic autonomy."

NEXT STEPS FOR THE GERMAN GOVERNMENT

Just like in its effort to separate itself from Russian energy resources, Germany must unquestionably be clear, precise, and direct with its communications to its citizens. Chancellor Sholz may have faltered a bit at the start in this respect. The decision to increase Germany's defense spending "was made in the inner circles of power, mostly between the chancellery, foreign ministry, and finance ministry," according to Mueller-Kaler. "Ordinary parliamentarians were only consulted once the course of action had already been taken." Although this delayed disclosure of information is understandable given the quickly unfolding circumstances materializing during the third and fourth day of the invasion, it reflects neither the collective decision-making of the Bundestag nor that of the German people.

At the end of the day, like in most other democratic countries, German citizens rely on a mix of what their government communicates and what is reported to them from abroad to receive their information. When an urgent event like the invasion of Ukraine takes place, public opinion changes as a result. "If the immediate event goes away, I'm not so sure that the change is going to stay," says Mildner. Financing defense capabilities will not be the general public's main priority after the war in Ukraine terminates and the ship goes back to drifting peacefully. However, German decision-makers within the political elite are there to keep the vessel on its new course. These individuals "know about the risk of China, the Middle East, and the Pacific" in the long-run, says Mildner, and they may thus be inclined to keep defense spending above NATO's 2% threshold far beyond the crisis.

Germany's immense economy has certainly made it stand out on the world stage. Its European allies expect it to be an active and meaningful bulwark to defend international norms. German politicians are prepared to accept this new role and the responsibility that entails, including smart troop placement, regular maintenance of weapons, and most importantly, the development of a national strategy. While fulfilling these obligations, Germany will probably try to avoid looking like a new "hegemonic presence in Europe," according to Barker. It just wants to be "one of the gang" in the EU, he added.

Caught unprepared in its energy and military strategy, the German ship is back on course and beginning a transformative process that may set it apart as a major power in the coming years. First, to uphold its commitment to territorial integrity and peace, Berlin will have to execute a gradual transition away from Russian energy while attempting to not erase its environmental progress in the renewable sector. It will also need to incrementally bolster its military expenditure in a way that does not overwhelm its unrehearsed forces. And finally, by increasing domestic communication and open exchanges of policy information with its neighbors, Germany can reimagine the role it plays in Europe and craft strategic responses to authoritarian powers that are unwilling to embrace a rules-based international system. In this way, Germany will have the opportunity to assume a much-needed leadership role in a Europe that has been shaken by an unthinkable war.

An expanded version of this article can be found online at thepolitic.org.

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BY **THOMAS BIRMINGHAM**

The Promise and Failure of New Haven's Civilian Review Board

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After Emma Jones' son Malik was murdered by police in 1997, she spent the next 23 years working to create a Civilian Review Board for police accountability. But now that one exists, she thinks it's time for New Haven to go back to the drawing board.

"GUYS, THIS isn't just, 'If you don't want to do something, don't do it.'"

Richard Crouse's plea to participate to the other 13 members of the New Haven Civilian Review Board (CRB) faded into the silence familiar to their Zoom meetings. As the board's November 2021 meeting trudged toward the two-hour mark, Crouse's eyes took to darting from notes to screen, notes to screen, and he would subtly but sharply bite his bottom lip whenever a member asked a question he'd answered minutes prior. He left this meeting as he often did: unsure what the board had accomplished.

Crouse, the board's secretary, typically bore the brunt of the tedious organizational work that had become the staple of the CRB, a group made up of everyday New Haven residents meant to generate accountability for police misconduct. He remembered innumerable volunteer hours spent combing over 70-page PDFs, compiling mountains of police data into spreadsheet categories like "Race," "Officer Name" and "Discipline Breakdown."

To the casual meeting observer, Crouse's face would be easily the most memorable, and he would appear to have the best handle on CRB operations.

"If you asked me what the process is for what happens on the Civilian Review Board, I truly couldn't tell you exactly," Crouse said.

At the same November meeting, silently taking notes with her camera off, was another face. A face that had virtually willed the CRB into existence. A face managing a tired smile, all but forgotten behind a black screen.

Forgotten, as if it wasn't because of Emma Jones such a meeting was happening at all. As if, in 1997, her legs hadn't given out after picking up the phone to hear "Oh, Ms. Jones, something really bad happened! Something really, really bad! There's a police officer and I believe he shot Malik!" As if she hadn't sat at the site of her son's murder every Monday since. As if she hasn't been fighting every moment to scrape together an institution like the CRB that would prevent these policing injustices, the kind that leaves family members buried in the dirt, from going unpunished.

But now, she said she's become marginalized in the course of establishing the enterprise that has become her life's work.

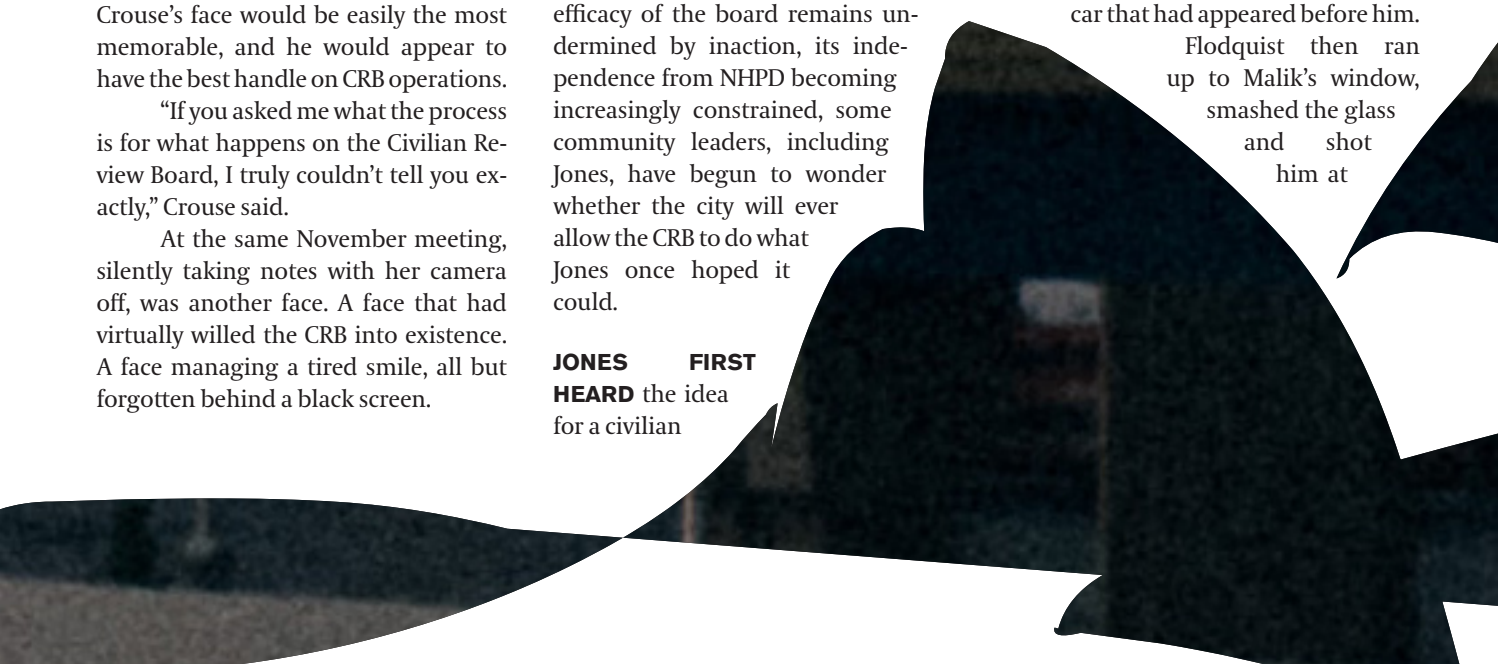
"I just do the observing," Jones said with pained modesty. "But they don't, you know, they don't typically see me. And from where I'm sitting now, from my lens, it's very grim."

Over the course of 25 years, Emma Jones, who now serves as an official consultant to the CRB, has worked to channel the violent loss of her son into creating a board that would fundamentally change the operations of the New Haven Police Department (NHPD), which has a long history of misconduct. But since January of 2019, when the New Haven Board of Alders voted to create the CRB, she has watched her vision slowly slip from her grasp. And as the supposed efficacy of the board remains undermined by inaction, its independence from NHPD becoming increasingly constrained, some community leaders, including Jones, have begun to wonder whether the city will ever allow the CRB to do what Jones once hoped it could.

JONES FIRST HEARD the idea for a civilian review board in 1995. The year prior, John Destefano had been elected mayor of New Haven and immediately promoted a campaign of heightened police activity common to American cities throughout the '90s. New Haven is home to a 34% Black population and a 57% white population which includes many short-term residents. As the use of policies like stop-and-frisk skyrocketed in this primarily Black and brown community, so did complaints of racial profiling and abuse. Eventually, public outcry escalated until Ward 3 Alder Anthony Dawson submitted a proposal for a CRB to the Board of Alders.

Dawson's proposal failed to pass. Little did Jones know, she would soon become its champion.

On the night of April 14, 1997, Malik Jones got in his car with his friend Samuel Cruz after a game of basketball in East Haven. As 21-year-old Malik drove home, Officer Robert Flodquist began following him. Noticing Flodquist in pursuit, Malik pulled into an empty lot on Grand Avenue and soon was boxed in by police cars. Before Malik had stopped the car, Flodquist exited his vehicle and began approaching the driver's side door from the rear. What happened next will never be known with total certainty: Flodquist claimed Malik reversed the car towards him in an attempt to flee, though Cruz said he was simply trying to avoid hitting the police car that had appeared before him. Flodquist then ran up to Malik's window, smashed the glass and shot him at



least four times above the heart. Flodquist later testified he kept shooting until Malik slumped over.

When she first got the call, Jones thought it was a really bad joke. Then an NHPD officer arrived at her door, and immediately she was paralyzed. She didn't yet know that officers at the scene of the shooting took the time to handcuff her son despite his bullet holes. She didn't yet know that her son vomited on himself as officers dragged him into a van. All she knew was that Malik was gone.

She said everyone who'd ever met her son fell in love with him.

"I had to pray to God so that I didn't lose my mind," Jones said. "I prayed for God to take the knife that was in my heart and pull it out and throw it in the river, in a fire someplace. And I begged God to give me a sign to let me know what to do."

She couldn't bring herself to do anything for three months, let alone bring herself to sleep. She felt helpless. Eventually, Jones started spending time each day dreaming of things she could do so other people would not have to suffer like this. Once a successful law associate herself, she soon got to work, bringing together groups of all kinds, from the NAACP to the Nation of Islam. They discussed new legislation, racial profiling education initiatives, public rallies, anything they could imagine, while Jones scribbled notes on a yellow legal pad.

"The police commit some of the most egregious atrocities against human beings in this country," Jones said. "Officer Flodquist violated every single policy and procedure of the police department. But there's no accountability, right? So the Civilian Review Board was one of the first things we decided we wanted."

Propelled by thoughts of Malik, she began traveling the country. From New Jersey to California, she searched for years for the perfect model on which to base her vision of a CRB. She discovered that no such model existed. Almost all CRBs either vanished into obscurity or were wholly ineffective. She returned to New Haven disheartened but armed with a comprehensive knowledge of what makes CRBs fail.

For Jones, the New Haven CRB needed several key elements in order to be worthwhile. It needed complete independence from police, so it could receive complaints and conduct full investigations without relying on police records. It needed "subpoena power," or the ability to summon witnesses and documents during investigations. It needed the authority to discipline officers, though she knew support for this would be hard to come by. And it would need an appropriate budget. Anything less, she believed, would ensure that New Haven's proposed CRB met the same perilous fate as the others.

But translating those components into actual city law turned out to be, unsurprisingly for Jones, a slow, laborious process. Establishing a new board like the CRB requires making changes to the New Haven City Charter, which may only be amended every 10 years. By the time Jones had drafted an ordinance in 2004, she learned that the charter had just been reviewed the year prior. She'd have to wait another decade. During that time, she began working more vigorously to build grassroots support for the idea.

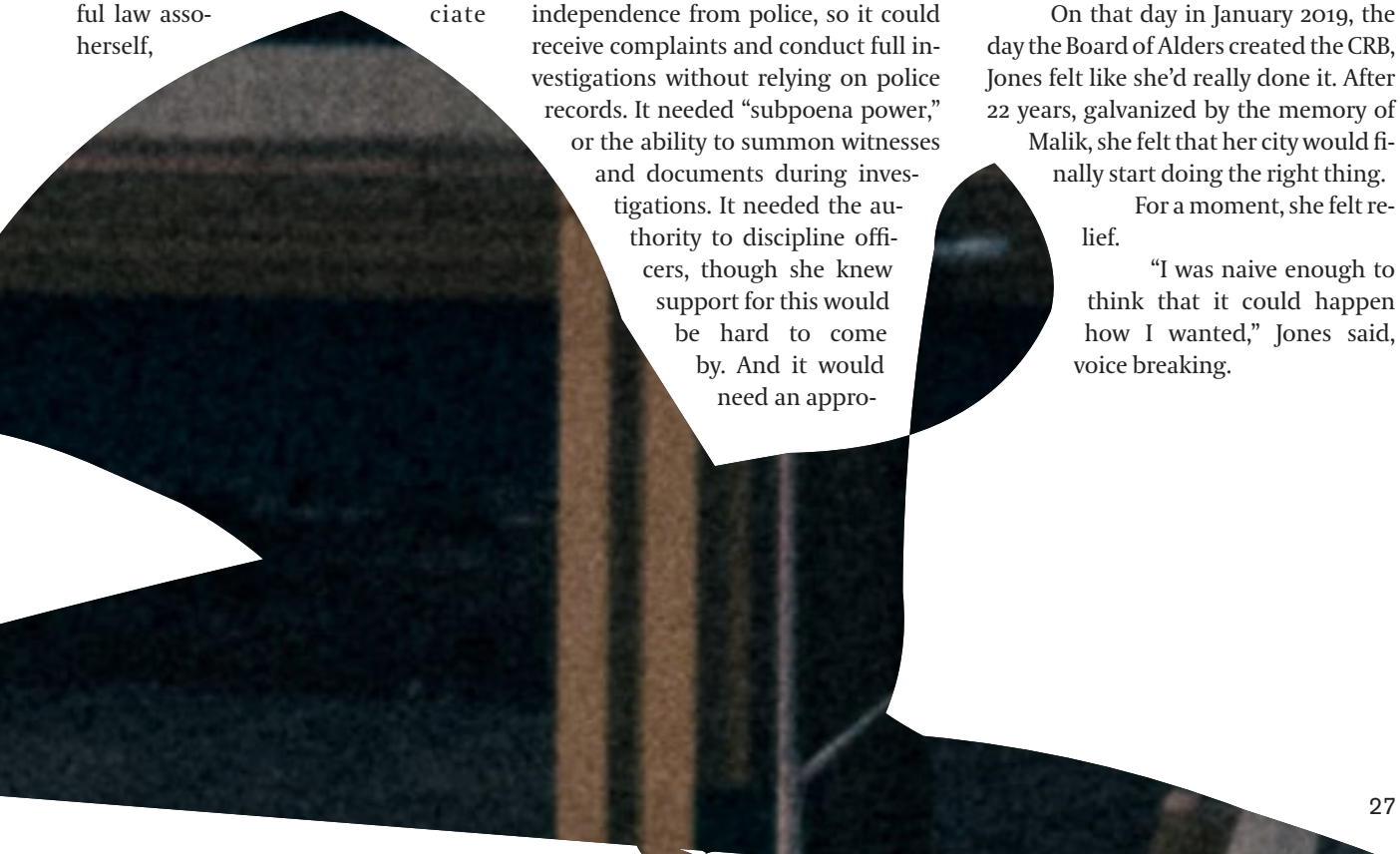
When the window finally opened again in 2013, and Jones and the NAACP helped propose a referendum to amend the charter to mandate that the city establish the CRB, it passed with overwhelming public support.

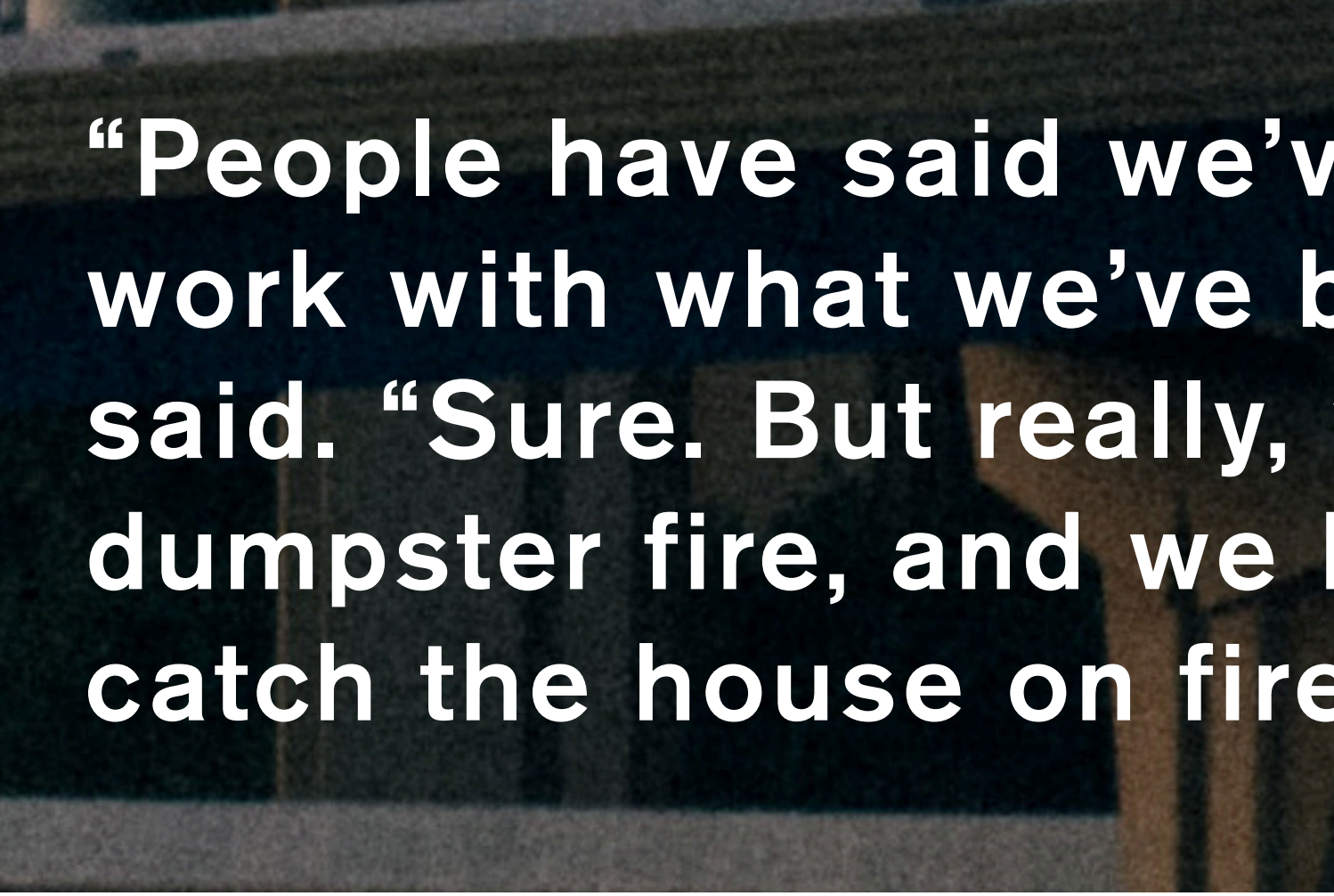
For a moment, she felt ecstatic. But in a city with over 500 police officers for just 144,000 people, it would be another six long years, thanks to dominant opposition from the police union, before referendum became reality.

On that day in January 2019, the day the Board of Alders created the CRB, Jones felt like she'd really done it. After 22 years, galvanized by the memory of Malik, she felt that her city would finally start doing the right thing.

For a moment, she felt relief.

"I was naive enough to think that it could happen how I wanted," Jones said, voice breaking.





THREE YEARS AFTER the official birth of the CRB, Crouse, who works full-time as a Program Administrator in Yale’s Office of New Haven Affairs, sat in the shade of a red brick pavilion, one bright blue pant leg crossed over the other. He was trying to sum up what it’s like to sit on the CRB, and he spent most of the interview leaning back in his chair with slightly slumped shoulders.

He described begging people to remember it exists at all.

“People have said we’ve done really great work with what we’ve been given,” Crouse said. “Sure. But really, we were given a dumpster fire, and we have managed to not catch the house on fire next to us. That’s it.”

When Crouse first reached out to the Board of Alders about the open CRB position, he didn’t at all realize what he signed up for. Unlike Jones, he has never had any consequential encounters with police. He grew up in Florida, not New Haven, and his background is a Ph.D. in neuroscience, not policing. He said he was just happy to try to help out the neighborhood he’d fallen in love with around Dwight Street.

The Board of Alders approved Crouse to the CRB in July of 2019. He waited for months for them to accept other members. He kept waiting. Nothing happened. Eventually, without even having their email addresses, Crouse decided to reach out to the other members via Facebook, and the ones that responded were in the same boat: not a clue what was going on.

One such member was Rev. Samuel Ross-Lee, the CRB’s member-at-large. He’d already been on the job for two months before Ward-29 Alder Brian Windgate, the CRB’s representative to the Board of Alders, told him he held this title. As he came to terms with that revelation, Ross-Lee said he had to lead the CRB through the six months of training sessions mandated by the city, but said that before those trainings concluded, the Board of Alders suddenly announced that the CRB was ready to see cases.

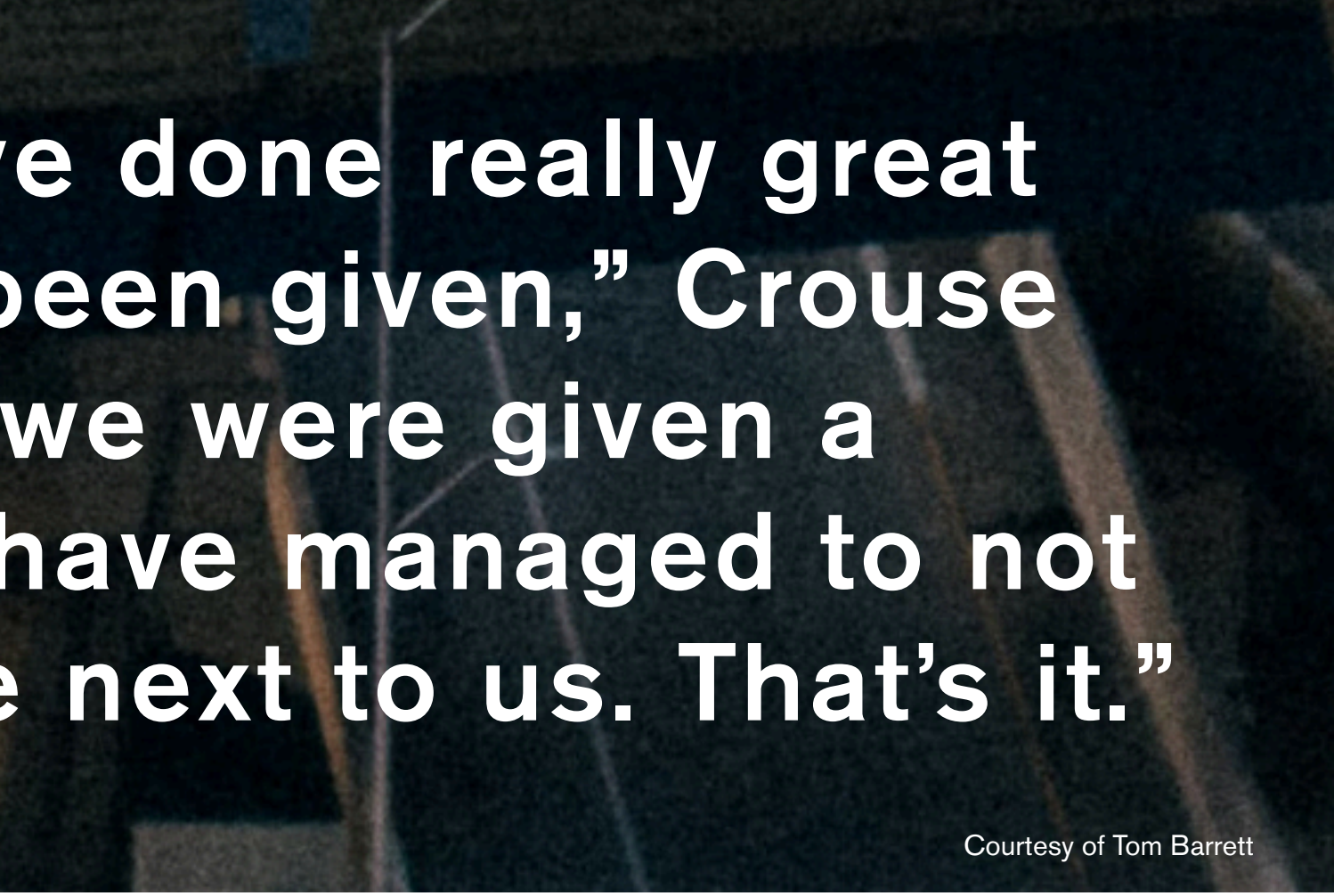
“I think the CRB was put before the public far too soon,” Ross-Lee said. “We got backed up significantly as a result.”

Now that the CRB, nearly two years after the passing of the ordinance which brought it to life, was holding meetings, Crouse said it felt like they might finally escape their state of limbo. But as each month ticked by, it seemed to Crouse that still nothing happened. The worst of it, he said, was the cameras.

At any given moment, no more than three or four members would have their cameras on at all. Many wouldn’t unmute even when prompted. At the board’s October 2021 meeting, Ross-Lee spent nearly a minute attempting to call on a member who had raised their hand and was met with silence, only for them to furiously unmute nearly 15 minutes later, not realizing they’d ever been called on.

“Why weren’t we slapped on the wrist for some of this stuff?” Crouse said, hand lodged in his black curls.

Windgate, often with his camera off himself, was unbothered by the participation conundrum. People should focus on the fact that the CRB exists at all, he said. That’s the accomplishment, he said. When these once-a-month meetings happen around meal times in people’s busy schedules, there are



Courtesy of Tom Barrett

going to be cameras off, he said. Even where police abuse is concerned.

"Cameras on, cameras off, you know, [the meetings are at] dinner time," Windgate said. "But those issues are about to go away because we're about to start meeting in person."

As of March, Crouse said there were still cameras off at the Civilian Review Board.

CONSIDERING THE CURRENT CRB members don't receive a single cent for their efforts, Jones said she could salute their very hard work.

But she also bemoaned the fact that many of the members, including Crouse, have no educational background in law or policing. There were 105 complaints to NHPD in 2021, a number that has increased steadily since 2015. These included 16 accusations of excessive force, nine accusations of criminal conduct and nine accusations of illegal stops, on top of uncountable unreported incidents. She said given the dedicated investigative eye each of these complaints requires, the lack of substantive training amongst current board members is not sustainable.

"The CRB needs a lot of help," Jones said. "I believe it takes time for an organization like this to evolve into its true capabilities. But I don't want you to give people the impression that we have a real, competent Civilian Review Board this year because that would not be true."

However, the city appears wholly disinterested in reassessing the current membership of the board, which includes only four Black members, for the foreseeable future.

On the city of New Haven's website, the CRB's homepage lists term expiration dates for all 14 members. Four of them, including Crouse's, expired in July of 2021. According to the CRB's ordinance, term limits are two years, or alternatively, "until a successor is appointed and duly qualified." Alder Windgate said that in light of how difficult the training process proved to be with so few meetings, how it took over a year for work to begin and the current lack of search for replacements, he believes it's best if everyone stays put for now.

"I think it would be a disservice to do a whole switcheroo," Windgate said. "The people invested have done their due diligence of hailing this whole new process. It's the Richard Crouses of the world."

Crouse feels completely in over his head.

He reached a breaking point around the time his term was originally intended to end. At 11:21 p.m. on July 19, 2021, after meeting upon meeting spent running into the same barriers, Crouse fired up a Google Doc, resolving to create a document that could serve as a summary of the CRB's expectations, duties and procedures.

As Crouse created his six-page grasp at deeper understanding, he tried to outline the four main duties of the CRB as he saw them: to independently review complaints of police misconduct, to monitor the methods by which complaints are processed at NHPD by essentially following their paper trails, to make recommendations to the po-

lice commissioners and to report annually on their work. The only sound in his room was the fraught clacking of keys.

When complaints are filed to the police department, they have five days to turn them over to the CRB. If the complaint has substance, the CRB designates a four-person Review Committee to the complaint to go over all the relevant files and footage. The Review Committee then presents their findings to the full CRB, which, after discussion, holds a vote on whether or not to approve the committee's proposed course of action, amend it or reject it. If the vote passes, a written report, which includes the CRB's disciplinary recommendations, must be drawn up and sent to the Board of Police Commissioners, which either approves or rejects their recommendations. And if they are rejected, there are no consequences. Finally, well past midnight, eyes straining, Crouse closed his laptop.

This is the extent of the CRB's power. Needless to say, this isn't what Jones had planned.

EVERY CRB MEETING starts the same: with a presentation led by police.

Every meeting, Jones sits behind her black screen and watches Lt. Manmeet Colon and Captain David Zannelli, who leads the NHPD Professional Standards and Training Division. The officers give a rundown of the complaints NHPD has investigated in the last month, the vast majority of which – 70% in 2020 – NHPD deems unfounded. Every meeting, she said she must hold her tongue as the police, who she fought to keep out of her life's work, dictate its course of action.

"This was supposed to be the first time in my life that there was a CRB that really stood firmly for that accountability," Jones said.

In her original plans for the board, Jones stressed the essentiality of a mechanism for citizens to file official complaints directly to the CRB. But today, the only way to get a complaint to them is through the police's Internal Affairs Division (IA).

Crouse said that he often finds the difference between police and CRB's investigative ability immensely frustrating. Last September, he found out about a certain type of IA log sheet with pages of racial demographic information of citizens filing complaints he was never told he had access to, and had to repeatedly beg to see again. Virtually all involved members, from Crouse to Ross-Lee to Windgate to Jones, were in agreement: IA's dominance over the CRB needs to end in order for it to truly fulfill its purpose of generating impartial accountability.

"If civilians don't feel comfortable going to the police, I do think it's important that they can follow up with us directly," Crouse said.

Captain Zannelli explained that even though all complaints are investigated first within the police department, IA gives the CRB access to all arrest and incident reports, body camera footage and their own reports of the investigations. He even said sometimes police policies are improved based on CRB feedback. When pressed for an example, Zannelli recounted a time when CRB members were pressuring NHPD to promote violence de-escalation tactics to officers. He said because he believes NHPD should be at the forefront of de-escalation practice, the department took an unspecified "portion" of CRB concerns into account. Yet Connecticut law had already mandated these reforms, so they would have had to be implemented regardless of CRB input.

Zannelli believes the CRB and police have fostered a good working relationship. Even when they disagree, considering NHPD has complete authority whether or not to accept CRB recommendations, they do so respectfully. In fact, out of everyone I spoke to, he was the most complimentary of the CRB.

"I would like the CRB to go back to the community and say the IA division is doing thorough investigations," Zannelli said. "There's not a boogeyman in the closet."

ON OCT. 7 OF LAST YEAR, Crouse remembers walking down Howard Street in New Haven, side-by-side with Captain Zannelli. He'd reluctantly agreed to assist the captain with an NHPD recruitment drive, going door to door with flyers, selling the idea of joining the force. He didn't think much of it. It was right by his lab. Armed with a large backpack, he shrugged off anxieties he was being too chummy with the department, and the pair took off through the Hill.

When the two reached the corner of Howard and Putnam, Zannelli spotted a group of young people and peeled off to begin his jovial pitch, paying no mind to the aging Black man sitting in front of Kav's Package Store. With Zannelli preoccupied, Crouse approached the man and extended a flier. The man turned to look up at him. He shook his head.

"You a cop?" he demanded, voice low, a shadow of worry overtaking his face.

"No, I'm not a cop." Crouse, with



his backpack, was mildly offended.

The man began muttering something Crouse couldn't make out, so he knelt down beside him. Not wanting to completely ignore Zannelli, however, Crouse kept one side of his face turned away from the man, hoping to continue hearing both speakers. He listened with one ear as the man's muttering continued.

"F these guys," he said. "You gotta watch out. They're putting on a smile now, but they're gonna shoot us."

In the ensuing silence, Crouse wished he could think of something reassuring to say. Wished he could give him clear instructions. Wished he could describe clear processes the CRB still didn't have, something to sum up his months of toil in a seconds-long exchange with one of the strangers the CRB was designed to advocate for.

All he was able to give this man was a hollow summary of the New Haven Civilian Review Board, and his phone number.

Crouse never heard back.

Zanelli would later report that NHPD received 523 applications thanks to the drive, their highest in four years. He thanked the CRB for what had been, for him at least, a team effort.

Yet at almost every stage of this "team effort" since the CRB's creation in 2019, NHPD and its accompanying police union have campaigned to undermine not only the CRB's independence, but its ability to function at all. The campaign started when the union backed West Haven officer Bob Proto's nomination to the CRB. The CRB's ordinance explicitly states no officers may serve on the board, but because Proto was recently retired, he was able to get around it. It was only due to widespread outcry that the Board of Alders ultimately shot down Proto's nomination.

In January 2022, the police union, led by president Florencio Cotto, filed a Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) complaint against the CRB. They claimed that the CRB violated its ordinance by failing to notify an officer being investigated for misconduct of a meeting where the board discussed their disciplinary recommendations for that officer. They hoped to stop public discussion of potential abuse while the Freedom of Information Commission conducted its investigation.

The campaign continues with NHPD's standoff-ish approach to the CRB's written recommendations. Crouse stressed that in the city ordinance, the CRB must always hear from the Board of Police Commissioners before any disciplinary rulings are given out on a complaint they investigated. The CRB is supposed to receive a response to their written reports and recommendations. As of March 2022, Crouse said they never have.

Justin Farmer, who sits on Hamden City Council, speaks with the knowledge of someone who has been attuned to police misconduct for many years. He remembers standing on the steps of NHPD, protesting in the aftermath of George Floyd's death, and getting pepper-sprayed by police despite being an acting elected official. He said it's absurd that the police have the sole authority over themselves, and his N95 ballooned at the force of his words.

"The police should not be investigating themselves," Farmer said of the NHPD's Internal Affairs Department. "If the city gets audited, we can't just have our own finance director say these numbers are good. When it comes to police, we always throw conventional wisdom out the window."

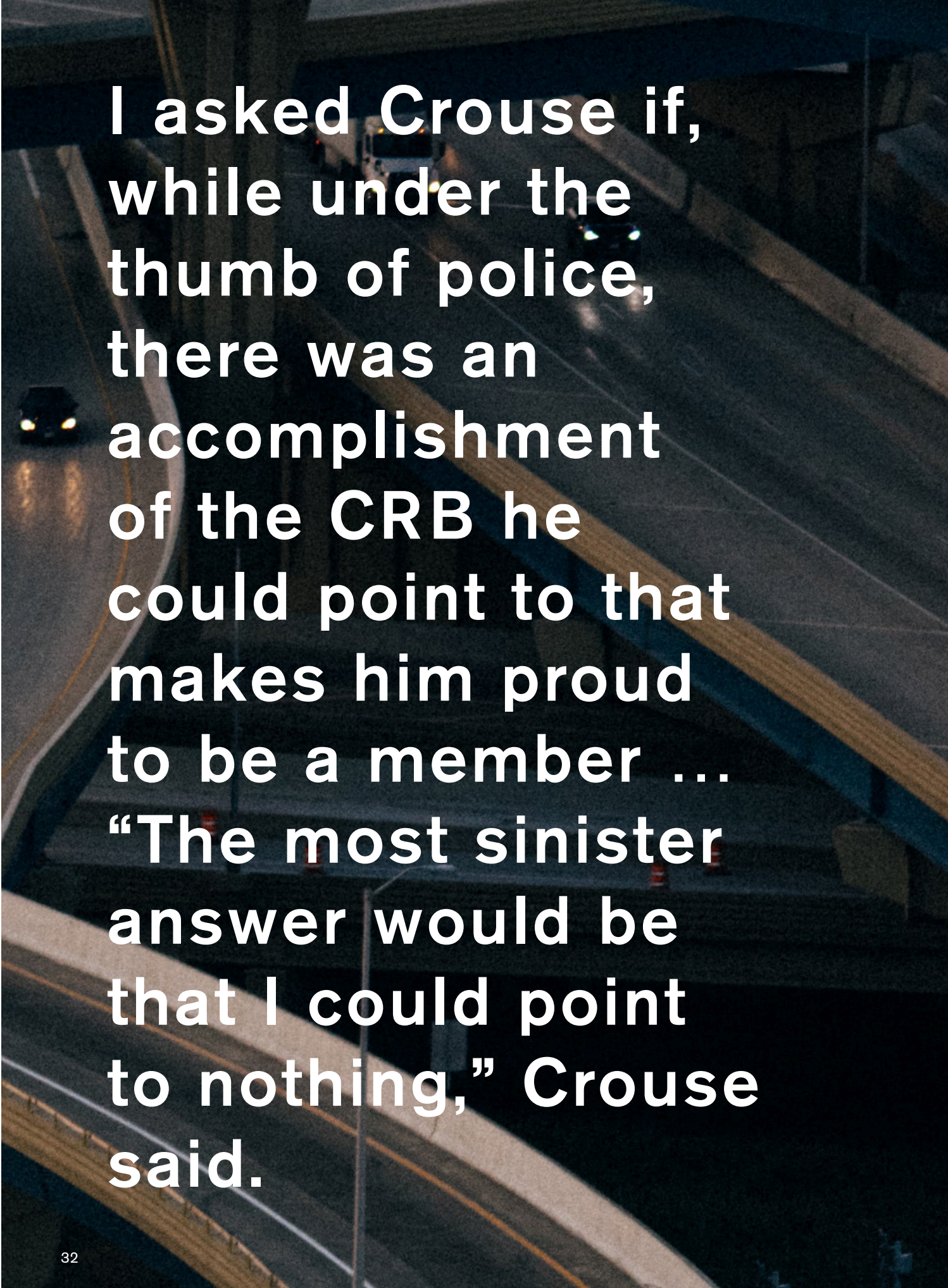
Jones, with her avalanche of notes, minute-by-minute meeting details on how her dream of police reform has fallen apart, still isn't really sure what happened. It was as though she blinked and her years putting together the ideal recipe for a CRB vanished. She said you couldn't imagine how frustrating it feels.

However, Jones said she wants people to know her criticisms don't come from a malicious place. She wishes more than anything she could trust NHPD with this work themselves. Alder Windgate certainly does, as he rejected the systemic nature of these issues within police, saying there are people that should be held accountable in every profession, from custodians to "Wall Street guys."

But the stories of Jones' son and countless others have made it impossible for her to feel comfortable granting police full responsibility for their own conduct.

"I don't want to be unfair to anyone because I know deep in my soul what that feels like," Jones said. "In the ideal world, I would like to see the police and the community working together to do the right thing. But it's not an ideal world."

Back under the red brick pavilion on Yale's campus, I asked Crouse if, while under the thumb of police, there was an accomplishment of the CRB he



I asked Crouse if, while under the thumb of police, there was an accomplishment of the CRB he could point to that makes him proud to be a member … "The most sinister answer would be that I could point to nothing," Crouse said.

could point to that makes him proud to be a member. He dropped eye contact with me and took a breath.

"The most sinister answer would be that I could point to nothing," Crouse said.

FOR 25 YEARS, Emma Jones has toiled over the CRB. Now, she believes that perhaps the city is better off without it.

"I'd rather not have a CRB that's not legitimate than give people false hope," Jones said. "This Civilian Review Board is not legitimate."

For Councilman Farmer, the CRB has amounted to a mere political football. A football meant for voters to chase, to appease them, and a football to be perpetually intercepted by infinitely more powerful entities like the police union. So while he's sympathetic to those working to better the CRB, ultimately, he just doesn't believe the city will ever take it seriously. If they did, he said, there would be conversations about how to turn the resources used on every officer disciplined or terminated into resources to go back into the community. But that's not the conversation the city is having.

"The Civilian Review Board has been a response to institutional racism, but it has been a shield to police," Farmer said, hand suddenly striking his knee. "Everyone loves reformist ideas like the CRB, but I cannot take it seriously until the city wants to say it will reinvest in the community."

The evidence of this lack of serious attitude toward efforts like the CRB, Farmer said, is in the city's spending patterns. It's the recent measure to fund a bunker with over 500 surveillance cameras rather than funding programs to keep kids off the streets. It's New Haven Mayor Justin Elicker promising money from the American Rescue Plan first and foremost to police.

Dr. Phillip Atiba Goff, the CEO of the Yale-based Center for Policing Equity (CPE), has observed many CRBs in many places. The Center boasts the world's largest collection of behavioral police data, providing Goff an outlet to holistically analyze CRB performance. And he echoed Farmer, saying the emphasis most cities place on police is typically a response to the choice not to provide other services. When places divest from housing, health care, child care and substance abuse, which all disproportionately impact Black people, police funding goes up in order to handle the repercussions.

Farmer and Goff are tired of the conversations around public safety beginning and ending with police.

"We must talk about policing within the context of generational racism and within the context of neighborhood divestment," Goff said.

Crouse, who spends most of his time in a Yale lab, not thinking about policing, said he's desperate to hear feedback from these neighborhoods. Both himself and Jones are trying to plan community engagement events in the near future, trying to make people aware of how badly the CRB needs help.

Because for Jones, watching people pontificate about these ideas isn't going to cut it anymore.

And for Crouse, he wants to, needs to, feel like all this work can really mean something for someone.

"I want the community to know that we need you to yell at us," Crouse said. "Hold us accountable, too. In some ways, it's not fair to put that on the shoulders of the people who are most affected by this. But I just want to be able to defend what the CRB is doing."

MALIK JONES was a remarkable athlete. He'd always excelled on the basketball court and even earned a black belt in karate. Malik's mother said he was the glue holding the family together, and in an instant, the police took that away from her. But that wasn't enough. Jones recounted how, in the aftermath of Malik's murder, she watched as the police tried to take the bright memory she had of Malik away from her too.

She watched Flodquist claim he received a tip that a red Subaru was speeding in the area, and that this tip led him to begin tailing Malik. Malik was driving a gray Oldsmobile Cutlass.

She watched the police pull the accusation that Malik's car was speeding at all seemingly out of thin air. Later investigations of the event revealed his car was incapable of going more than 40 miles per hour.

She watched as a Black NHPD officer approached her days after Malik's death, saying he arrived at the scene as officers were searching the car. He told her he stopped them from planting a gun in the trunk.

She watched Robert Flodquist never face a single consequence for Malik's murder. He was promoted shortly after the killing and continues to receive a sizable pension to this day.

In a way, Jones said the police have also taken away the New Haven CRB, the project that arose from the pain of their taking of her son. She watched it enter their sphere of influence and inevitably become separated from its original purpose. And now, Jones said she feels weary. Weary in the face of being denied justice for a long time.

But despite everything, Jones still can't help but see the potential in this idea. She said the board's goal is to begin cycling in new membership in December. She refuses to give up hope that there's some way to fix this mess.

Because if her fight has taught her anything, it's that she must keep standing up, no matter the cost.

"I think something like a miracle would have to happen to get the kind of results I have in mind for the CRB," Jones said. "It's time to go back to the drawing board. But I haven't given up on it yet, because in this fight there is no giving up."

ADVOCATING F

A Conversation with Ukrainian Student Activist

BY **LEONIE WISOWATY and KATE REYNOLDS**

Anastasiia Pereverten is a Ukrainian student activist who is currently an exchange student at the University of Wyoming in the UGRAD program. She is the only student from Ukraine at UW, and when Russia invaded Ukraine, she began to advocate for her country on campus. Anastasiia has given a host of interviews, including with USA Today *and local Wyoming papers. She spoke with* The Politic *over Zoom about the war, her activism, and the historical context that frames her advocacy.*

DID YOU LEARN ABOUT THE HISTORY OF UKRAINE AND RUSSIA IN HISTORY CLASSES? WHAT SENSE DID YOU GET OF THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN THE TWO COUNTRIES? AND HOW DID THAT CHANGE AFTER THE RUSSIAN ANNEXATION OF CRIMEA?

I learned about all of that during history class in school. Until the Revolution of Dignity [a popular uprising that ousted Ukrainian President Viktor Yanukovych in 2014 following his decision to seek closer ties with Russia instead of the European Union], I didn't even think about a clear division between our countries and our culture. They were smashed in popular culture. That's an important note. They were not merged in everyone's mind and in every respect, but it was presented on TV and in other popular media as being almost one theme.

The Revolution of Dignity started when I was in fifth grade. I remember sitting on a couch at my grandmother's sister's flat and watching a TV broadcast recapping the story of the occupation of Crimea. I felt an animalistic fury, thinking how it's impossible to take away a part of a country. You cannot imagine something that barbaric happening.

From the fifth grade on, in every school, you take a Ukrainian history course. And every lesson affirms the notion that you've never been friends or brothers [with Russia], you've always been enemies, that [Russia] will always try to destroy the idea of our independence and culture and language. Then when I entered university, I decided to major in cultural studies. So, it's about the same thing. We learn about undoubtable and indisputable arguments for Ukraine being a state with a continued history of statehood, and a continuous history of independence. Russia is ignoring that. That is what we are now witnessing. They just don't acknowledge our independence.

ROM ABROAD

Anastasiia Pereverten

2014 was a turning point. My generation was raised with the events of the Revolution of Dignity in mind. More than one hundred people died [during the protests] in my city, fighting for Ukrainian freedom, the right to be free and independent, and not to comply with a dictator. This was the knowledge that I inherited. People have the power to change this at any point. If you decide to act, you are able to change anything — any dictator, any oligarch, any system. It will likely take sacrifices, but it's possible. I was 11 [at the time of the Revolution of Dignity], but now I'm 18. I believe that event shaped me as an individual, and it played the very same role for many of my peers.

TELL US ABOUT THE MOMENT YOU FOUND OUT RUSSIA HAD INVADED UKRAINE. WHAT WAS GOING THROUGH YOUR MIND AT THAT MOMENT, ESPECIALLY AS YOU WERE SO FAR AWAY FROM HOME?

There were lots of public discussions about Russian troops at the border, I believe in October. But we were pretty confident that it was just a political pressure game, and they wouldn't end up doing anything. It wasn't unusual for Ukrainians to hear this — we've been living through that since 2014. There is constantly a fear of escalation, a fear of a new wave of attacks, a fear of bombings of eastern Ukraine, or of cyber-attacks happening with governmental and private labs in Ukraine. So, it felt just like an ordinary situation.

I believe it was on February 16th, when Putin had a conference with his government officials. After that day, I started to feel extremely strained because all the headlines in the US media were posting only about the fear of invasion. It was always phrased as a tragedy you could not avoid. But it was impossible for me to believe. I thought that kind of escalation might happen in eastern Ukraine, but I could never, ever even guess that Russia would start bombing Kyiv.

I remember February 23rd in very small details. In Ukraine the war started on the 24th, but because of the time difference, here it was the 23rd.

At 8 PM, I opened Twitter, and saw messages that the war had started. I thought it was fake, so I started Googling and found out that the first explosion in Kyiv was 20 minutes from my home. When you're reading about that, the only thing you can imagine is your house being bombed. No one is alive, probably. It's the end of the world. This fear, it's numbing.

I could not even start crying when I read it. You're just in shock. I started to message my friends, my parents and grandparents. No one replied. I started calling them. It was 5 AM in Ukraine,

so they were probably asleep. Nobody picked up. Then my dad called me, saying, "Yes, a couple of explosions happened, but you have nothing to worry about. We're okay, we're just waiting for instructions from the government and packing our things in a suitcase in case of an evacuation."

After an hour or so, the initial shock disappeared, and I just started to think of ideas of what I can do. So I stayed awake, and for the whole night, I was painting. I painted 100 or so stickers of Ukrainian flags. I don't know why. I just had the idea that it would help to spread the word and encourage students to donate or get involved. I wrote a letter, and I left all the stickers and my letter in the basement of a residence hall. Throughout the whole night, I was tracking the news and reading every message that I could find on Telegram [a social media messaging app] about the war.

A crucial thing I did on the first day of the war was write a couple of letters with relevant ways to address this topic on campus. The average level of knowledge about Ukraine in the US is cursory. So I created a list of actions that students and professors might be able to do, and I sent those letters to the president, to my professors, and my international advisor. On the second day of the war, I started meeting all these people, and we started acting together to support Ukraine here.

DO YOU KNOW WHERE YOUR FAMILY AND FRIENDS ARE NOW IN UKRAINE? WHAT HAVE THEY BEEN TELLING YOU ABOUT THE WAR?

All of my family stayed in Ukraine. The second day of the war was the most intimidating — the Russian soldiers took over Chernobyl and there was a threat of catastrophe. That made my sibling and my mother extremely scared. They were saying goodbye to me. But the situation stabilized, and they moved to the suburbs, which is relatively safe. They started to feel secure, and they have the support of the whole family. It's one house with thirteen people living there.

A couple of days ago during the night, [my family] heard the sounds of aircrafts. You get extremely frightened every time you hear anything. And my brother was trembling, hearing the sounds, even after feeling secure and not hearing anything for the last couple of weeks.

My family stays as strong and calm as possible. They're supporting each other, staying positive, and making jokes. I call them every day. My grandma knows how pathetic coffee is in the US, so every time I call her, she says, "Is the coffee still that bad?" And it's still bad. And she's like, "My coffee is 100 times better." She's been neglecting the fear. She said "No, I'm not afraid. I'm not afraid. It's our state, we're staying. We're staying."

And I'm honestly stoked about the bravery and the courage of Ukranians. For instance, my mom's cousin, he's in the army and my mom's sibling is in the territorial defense. People were staying in lines for days to register for territorial defense. And I believe the whole world was deeply impressed and inspired by Ukrainians' bravery and courage, and their aspiration to sacrifice their lives for the future of their children, for their culture, and for their people.

WHAT IS IT LIKE TALKING TO AMERICANS ABOUT THE WAR IN UKRAINE?

We had three days of tabling in the [University of Wyoming] student union building to share knowledge about Ukraine. We had two rallies, both were educational, not only to express solidarity with Ukraine, but also to inform people on what Ukraine is, the history of Ukraine, and the context of the war. We also wanted to share knowledge of how to support Ukraine, to whom to donate, and whom you can rely on for truthful information or credible donations.

The international office of the UW also organized a conversation with a retired US ambassador and an economics professor. Next week we are going to have a lecture from a Returned Peace Corps Volunteer who has been working in Ukraine for some time. We're planning two screenings for documentaries about Ukrainian history. Also, I composed a list of books about Ukraine in English so that the university library can acquire them,

so that we have a certain amount of information accessible for the faculty and students. We're taking actions in the right direction.

Last Friday, I asked a retired US Ambassador about Crimea. And I said, "Hey, I'm just wondering, when Crimea was annexed, why was the US reaction so weak?" He said, "Oh, I don't know. But maybe there's just a general idea that Crimea is kind of part of Russia." And that's a historical myth. That's a part of the propaganda. That's the narrative being imposed by the Russian government through their propagandistic machine.

And now we must debunk those myths, all of them, to build a new Ukrainian narrative for the world. Otherwise, we won't receive enough long-term support, even after our victory.

WHAT DO YOU THINK IS YOUR MAIN GOAL WITH YOUR ADVOCACY? IS THERE SOMETHING SPECIFIC THAT YOU FEEL LIKE YOU WANT TO RAISE AWARENESS ABOUT?

The core goal is to act until victory and do everything I can to change the community I'm living in right now. I want to involve and engage people to donate and raise awareness about Ukrainian authenticity because too many things have been stolen by Russia, in terms of cultural heritage, and it's unacceptable. I would love for people to be informed about Ukraine being a historically independent country with its own culture and history.

However, it is important not to shift attention away from the army. The army is the biggest priority right now. It is the most crucial and lifesaving thing for us.

HOW DO YOU WANT THE U.S. GOVERNMENT OR THE WORLD TO ADDRESS THIS WAR? WHAT DO YOU THINK WE CAN DO TO MAKE THIS WAR END?

Generally, governments need to get sober from the illusion that they can appease Russia. The Russian government is probably mad. And any rational arguments just don't seem reasonable to them. The idea of being afraid of provoking World War Three is absurd.

War is happening, but now Ukraine is fighting for the whole of Europe. If you have ever heard of Russian retorts, they're always threatening not only Ukraine but also European countries. They've been claiming their spread over Poland, over Baltic countries. They will not stop with Ukraine. If you struggle to believe that, you should just translate any rebroadcast of Russian governmental TV channels and you will have no doubts left.

The world leaders who have visited Ukraine within the last two weeks after the Bucha massacre have no illusions. They do not treat this war as something distant. They see how terrifying the actions of the Russian army are, and they fully understand the importance of acting in the fastest way possible.

Every [American] citizen has a chance to address their representatives. So, I highly encourage this. We were printing instructions [for University of Wyoming students] on how to address the governor in the fastest way possible. Organizing and participating in rallies is a way to draw the attention of your representatives and governments towards issues – that's extremely important right now.

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